



The OneVision Playbook

How I built a local marketing agency from a dorm room — and the system you can run yourself.

Isaiah Wright

ONE VISION GROUP

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Software and pricing accuracy. Tool interfaces, carrier requirements, and fees described in this book were accurate as of the date noted in the relevant chapter. They change. Verify current requirements before you rely on them.

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How to use this book

This is a working manual, not a book you read once and shelve. It's built to sit open on a second monitor while you do the thing.

IF YOU HAVE NO CLIENTS YET

Read it front to back, in order. The chapters are sequenced the way the work actually happens, and skipping ahead to the automation chapters before you've talked to a single business owner is the most common way people waste a year.

Do the **Do This Now** box at the end of each chapter before moving on. Each one is a single action sized to finish in under 45 minutes. There are eighteen of them. If you do all eighteen, you will have chosen a market, built an offer, priced it, written your outreach, run calls, and stood up delivery — in that order.

IF YOU ALREADY HAVE CLIENTS

Use the stage tag at the top of each chapter. Every chapter belongs to one of seven stages, and the stage tells you what problem it solves. If your problem is that nobody replies to your outreach, go to VOLUME. If your problem is that clients leave after two months, go to PROOF. Read what you need.

THE ASSET VAULT

Every script, template, worksheet, and checklist in this book also exists as a standalone file you can fill in. They're listed in the back, indexed by chapter. Use those rather than retyping out of the book.

A NOTE ON THE NUMBERS

Where a number appears in this book, it is one of two things and it will always say which: something measured in the author's own business, or an illustrative example built to show how the arithmetic works. There is no third category. Nothing here is a benchmark you should measure yourself against, because a benchmark from someone else's market is worse than no benchmark at all.

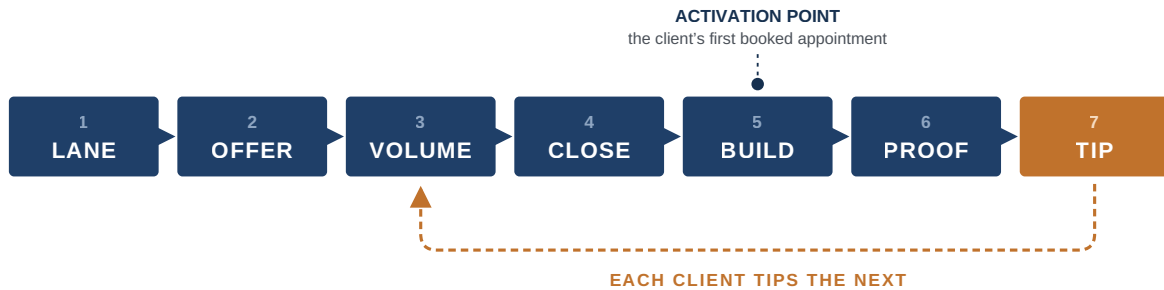
Track your own numbers from week one. By month three they will be the only numbers that matter.

ABOUT THE VOICE

The author's name is Isaiah Wright. His friends call him Zay. He wrote this in first person, and where he says "I did this," he did it. Where the book says "you're going to," that's the instruction.

The Domino System

Seven stages. The first client is the hardest thing you will do. Each one after costs less — because each one tips the next.



1 • LANE — Choose one vertical and one radius you can physically drive to. Written down, today.

2 • OFFER — Build one offer at one price, sold in booked appointments, not vague "leads."

3 • VOLUME — A daily touch count you hit whether or not you feel like it, tracked in a pipeline.

4 • CLOSE — Diagnose before you pitch. End the call with a decision, not a "let me think."

5 • BUILD — Register for messaging first, then stand up the machine. Drive hard at the activation point.

6 • PROOF — Report in the client's language: appointments and jobs won, not impressions.

7 • TIP — Ask at the moment the result lands. The referral re-enters at VOLUME, already half closed.

Stages 1 and 2 you do once and revisit. Stages 3 through 7 are the loop you live in. The dotted line is the whole point of this book: work done at stage 7 shows up as easier work at stage 3, which is why the tenth client costs a fraction of what the first one did.

PART ONE

The Setup

Before the scripts, before the software, before anything you can buy: the two decisions that determine whether any of it works.

STAGES COVERED · **LANE** · **VOLUME**

1

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · THE WHOLE IDEA

The First Domino

By the end of this chapter you'll understand why the first client costs everything and the tenth costs almost nothing — and you'll stop reading the curve backwards.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The day you got your first paying client. Where you were standing. What time of year — in season or out. Who they were and what they sell. What you charged. What you actually said. And the honest part: did you know how to do the work yet when they said yes?

I want to tell you about the part nobody puts in the ad.

Everybody selling you an agency course shows you month eighteen. The dashboard with eleven clients on it. The calendar with six calls booked before lunch. What they don't show you is month one, when you sent forty messages and got two replies and both of them were no.

Here's what I know now that I didn't know then. Those two curves are the same curve. You're just looking at it from the wrong end.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

The first client is the hardest thing you will ever do in this business. Every client after that costs less than the one before it.

That's it. That's the whole book in one sentence, and everything else in here is a method for surviving long enough to prove it to yourself.

Why most people get this backwards

Ask somebody who has never run an agency what the hard part is, and they'll tell you it's scaling. Going from one client to ten. Hiring. Systems. The stuff that sounds hard because it involves spreadsheets.

So they brace for the wrong thing. They spend three months building a website, picking a logo, registering an LLC, and watching videos about how to scale — all before a single business owner has ever heard their name. Then they send their first batch of messages, get ignored, and conclude they picked the wrong niche.

They didn't pick the wrong niche. They just met the hardest part of the job and thought it was a sign.

Think about what you're actually carrying when you go after client number one. No case study. No screenshot of a result. No name they recognize. No one who can vouch for you. Nothing but a claim, from a stranger, about a thing they've probably already been pitched on twice this month.

Now think about what you're carrying when you go after client number ten. A client in their industry who will take a phone call and say you're good. Numbers from a real account. A story about the exact problem this person has, because you fixed it in April for someone two towns over.

Same you. Same offer. Completely different weight.

Client one is a cold pitch from a nobody. Client ten is a warm introduction from someone they trust. You are not doing the same job twice.

The system

This is why the book is built the way it is.

The Domino System has seven stages, and they run in a loop. You'll see the full map on the page before this chapter, and every chapter from here tells you which stage it belongs to.

Stages one and two you do once, then revisit occasionally. **LANE** is choosing a market you can physically drive to. **OFFER** is building one thing you sell at one price.

Stages three through seven are the loop you actually live in:

VOLUME is outreach — a daily number you hit whether or not you feel like it.

CLOSE is turning a conversation into a signature. **BUILD** is standing up the machine that delivers. **PROOF** is making the result visible to the person paying for it.

TIP is turning that result into the next client.

The dotted line on the map matters more than the boxes. It runs from stage seven back to stage three. A referred prospect re-enters at VOLUME — but they arrive already half closed, because somebody they trust already told them you're worth talking to.

That's the domino. You don't get a shortcut on the first one. You earn a shortcut on every one after.

THE MATH OF IT, IN HOURS

Forget dollars for a second, because if you're starting out your real currency is hours.

Say client one takes you 60 hours of outreach, follow-up, calls, and rework to land. That's an illustrative number, not a promise — plug in your own once you have it.

Client two comes partly warm, because client one has now said something nice to somebody. Maybe it takes 40 hours. Client three, 25. By client six you have proof, a script that works, and a referral or two arriving without you asking.

Nothing about you got smarter between client one and client six. You just stopped starting from zero every time.

The mistake is to look at that 60-hour first client and decide the whole business costs 60 hours per client. It doesn't. That's the entry fee, paid once.

Failure modes

You quit in the flat part.

FIX — Write down, today, the number of outreach attempts you're willing to make before you allow yourself to conclude the method is broken. Make it a big number and make it before you're discouraged. Deciding that number while you feel fine is the only way it survives the week you feel terrible.

You rebuild the plan instead of running it.

FIX — Changing your niche, your offer, and your script in the same week means you learn nothing from any of them. Change one thing, run enough volume to see whether it moved, then change the next.

You treat the first client like the last one you'll ever get.

FIX — Underpricing to get a yes feels smart at the time and sets a ceiling you'll fight for a year. Charge what the work is worth even when you're nervous — Chapter 5 shows you how to figure out what that is.

You get client one and stop doing outreach.

FIX — Delivery eats the whole week, outreach stops, and sixty days later you're back at zero with one client and no pipeline. The daily number in Chapter 2 does not pause because you got busy.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Attempts to first yes. One number: how many businesses you contacted before one agreed to pay you. Count every attempt, including the ones that went nowhere.

You only get to measure it once, so write it down when it happens. It becomes the number you compare everything else against — and the number you give the next person who tells you this doesn't work.

What "good" looks like: there isn't a published figure worth trusting here, and anyone who quotes you one is guessing. Your number depends on your market, your channel, and how bad your first fifty messages are. Track it, beat it next time.

DO THIS NOW

20 minutes

Open a note on your phone and write two things.

First: the number of outreach attempts you'll make before you're allowed to decide this doesn't work. Pick something that would embarrass you to fall short of.

Second: the date you're writing it.

That's the whole exercise. You're making a promise to yourself while you're still fresh, because the version of you in week five is going to want to renegotiate, and this note is what he has to argue with.

2

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 3 — VOLUME

It's a Numbers Game

By the end of this chapter you'll have a daily number you can hit without motivation, and you'll understand why the return shows up after the volume instead of during it.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The grind before the first yes. How long it actually took. Roughly how many businesses you contacted. What a day looked like — lifts, class, practice, film, and where the agency work physically fit. And the lowest point: the day it felt stupid and you thought about dropping it.

I say this to everyone who asks me how I did it, and most of them look disappointed.

It's a numbers game. Put the work in, and eventually enough comes back that it feels worth it.

That's not the answer people want. People want a script. They want the specific message that made a landscaper reply. And I get it — a script feels like a thing you can hold. A number feels like being told to work harder, which is what your uncle says when he doesn't know what your job is.

But I mean something specific by it, and the specific version is worth more than any script I could hand you.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

The return arrives after the volume, not during it. Most people quit while the math is still working.

Why most people get this wrong

Here's the trap, and almost everyone walks into it.

You send fifty messages in week one. You get three replies and no calls. You conclude the message is broken. So you rewrite it. Week two, you send fifty of the new one. Two replies, one call, no close. You conclude the offer is broken. So you change the offer. Week three, new niche.

Three weeks in, you have run three experiments, learned nothing from any of them, and you feel like you worked hard. You did work hard. You just spent all of it re-deciding instead of doing.

The reason this feels right is that it looks like optimization. It looks like you're being smart and iterating. But you can't read a signal out of fifty attempts. Fifty is noise. Whatever result you got from those fifty, you'd get a meaningfully different result from the next fifty with the exact same message — that's just variance.

Changing your message every week isn't iteration. It's a way of feeling productive while never finding out whether anything works.

The other half of the trap is emotional. A bad week feels like evidence. It isn't. It's a sample. And you are the worst possible judge of your own sample size, because you're the one absorbing every no.

The system

1. PICK A DAILY NUMBER, NOT A WEEKLY ONE

Weekly targets get back-loaded. You tell yourself you'll do 100 this week, do 12 by Thursday, and then either cram 88 into Friday badly or quietly move the goal.

Daily numbers don't let you hide. You either hit today's or you didn't, and you find out in 24 hours instead of seven days.

Make it a number of attempts, not outcomes. You don't control replies. You control sends.

2. SET IT AT THE LEVEL YOU CAN HIT ON YOUR WORST DAY

This is the part people get backwards. They set the number for their best day — the Sunday afternoon with nothing else on. Then Tuesday happens, with a full day of work or class and something going wrong, and they miss it. Miss it three times and the number stops meaning anything.

Set it for the worst realistic day you'll have this month. If that's 15, it's 15. A 15 you hit every single day beats a 40 you hit twice a week, because the 15 compounds and the 40 turns into a story about how you're "not consistent."

You can always do more on a good day. Extra is extra. The floor is the thing you defend.

3. PUT IT IN A FIXED BLOCK, AT A FIXED TIME

Anything that doesn't have a time doesn't happen. Pick the block and defend it like a practice you can't skip.

The best block is usually early, before the day starts making demands. Second best is whatever gap actually exists in your real schedule — not the one you wish you had.

4. TRACK ATTEMPTS, REPLIES, AND CONVERSATIONS. THREE NUMBERS.

Not in your head. Your head lies about this, in both directions — you'll feel like you did tons of outreach on a week you did four, and you'll feel like you're failing on a week you did great.

Attempts is what you sent. **Replies** is anyone who wrote back, including the rude ones. **Conversations** is anyone who engaged past the first exchange.

Chapter 7 shows you how to track this properly inside a pipeline. For this week, a note on your phone with three tally marks is enough.

5. DO NOT CHANGE ANYTHING FOR THE FIRST 300 ATTEMPTS

Three hundred is not a magic number. It's just big enough that the result means something and small enough to reach in a few weeks.

Run the same message, to the same kind of business, through the same channel, 300 times. Then look at the three numbers and change one thing.

This is the hardest instruction in the chapter and the one that separates people who build something from people who have a folder of half-tested ideas.

BEFORE YOU SEND A SINGLE TEXT

If any of your outreach happens over SMS, you need A2P 10DLC registration first. Since February 2025, US carriers block unregistered application-to-person traffic outright — your messages don't get delivered slowly, they don't get delivered at all. Registration takes days, not minutes. Chapter 11 walks the whole process. Start it before you need it.

The asset

DAILY REP TRACKER — ONE ROW PER DAY

DATE	ATTEMPTS	REPLIES	CONVOS	NOTES
------	----------	---------	--------	-------

_____	_____	_____	_____	_____
-------	-------	-------	-------	-------

Weekly total: _____

Reply rate: replies / attempts = _____%

Convo rate: convos / attempts = _____%

Attempts to date: _____ (target before changing anything: 300)

Print it, or copy it into a spreadsheet. The full version is in the asset vault as **Daily Rep Tracker**.

Failure modes

You set the number for the person you wish you were.

FIX — Cut it in half. Hit the smaller number for two straight weeks before you raise it. Consistency at a low number beats intensity at a high one, because only one of them survives a bad Tuesday.

You count outcomes instead of attempts.

FIX — Targets like "book two calls today" put your daily win in someone else's hands. Track outcomes as a result, never as the goal. The goal is always something you can do alone.

You stop the day you land a client.

FIX — This is the most expensive one in the book. Delivery expands to eat the week, outreach stops, and two months later you have one client and an empty pipeline. Protect the block on delivery weeks too, even at a reduced number.

You rewrite the message after a bad morning.

FIX — Log the bad morning and keep sending. The 300 rule exists precisely to protect you from the version of yourself who has just been ignored eleven times before breakfast.

You do the volume but never look at the numbers.

FIX — Volume without measurement is just effort. Total the three columns every Sunday — it takes four minutes and it's the only way you'll ever know which change actually helped.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Reply rate — replies divided by attempts. This tells you whether your message and your targeting are working. It moves when you change who you contact or what you say first.

Conversation rate — conversations divided by attempts. This tells you whether the interest is real. A high reply rate with a low conversation rate usually means your opener is interesting but your offer isn't landing.

What "good" looks like: your own last 300 attempts. That's the only benchmark that means anything. Published reply-rate figures come from other people's markets, channels, and lists, and measuring yourself against them will either scare you off something that's working or make you comfortable with something that isn't.

DO THIS NOW

30 minutes

Three things, in order.

One. Look at your actual calendar for the next seven days — the real one, with class and work and everything else in it. Find the block that exists every single day. Write the time down.

Two. Pick the number you could hit inside that block on your worst day this month. Be honest and go low.

Three. Set a recurring calendar event for that block, every day, starting tomorrow. Title it with the number. Not "outreach" — the actual number, so you see it before you open it.

Then do tomorrow's.

IT'S A NUMBERS GAME

3

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 1 — LANE

Pick a Lane You Can Drive To

By the end of this chapter you'll have one vertical and one radius written down — chosen with a scorecard in an afternoon instead of agonized over for six months.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

How you actually ended up serving the verticals you serve. Did you sit down and choose landscaping, or did a landscaper say yes first and the rest followed? Be honest about which — the honest version is more useful to the reader than the tidy one.

Niche selection is where more beginners stall out than anywhere else in this business, and it's not close.

Not because it's hard. Because it's the last decision you can make without talking to anybody. Once you pick, the next thing on the list is contacting strangers, and there is an enormous psychological pull toward staying in the part where you're still "planning."

I've watched people spend eleven weeks on this. Spreadsheets. Reddit threads. Three different YouTube frameworks. At the end of eleven weeks they had a niche they weren't confident in and eleven fewer weeks.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Pick a lane you can drive to in twenty minutes, where one extra booked job obviously covers your fee. Then start. The lane sharpens with data you don't have yet.

Why most people get this wrong

Two mistakes, and they pull in opposite directions.

The first is picking a niche you can't reach. Somebody reads that med spas have high margins, so they decide they serve med spas — nationally. Now they're a stranger on the internet competing with fifty other strangers on the internet, with no reason for anyone to pick them.

The second is refusing to pick at all. "I'll work with any local business." That sounds flexible and it's actually the most expensive choice on the board, because every conversation starts from scratch. You can't reuse a single sentence, and you never build the thing that makes client three easier than client one.

There's a third thing worth naming, and it contradicts most advice you'll hear.

You will probably not choose your niche. Your niche will choose you — whoever says yes first. That is a completely acceptable way to start, as long as you notice it happening.

CONFIRM BEFORE PUBLICATION

This section asserts that Isaiah's lane emerged rather than being chosen up front, based on "one client led to another." If he actually picked deliberately, this whole section should be cut, not softened — the value here is honesty, and a hedged version is worse than either true version.

The reason this matters: if you believe you must pick correctly before starting, then picking becomes a high-stakes decision and you'll avoid it. If you believe you're picking a direction that will sharpen once real businesses start replying, you'll pick this afternoon.

Both are true. The direction matters. The precision doesn't, yet.

The system

THE SIX SCREENS

Four of these come from Alex Hormozi's criteria for choosing an audience — a growing market, one with money, one that's easy to target, one in pain. They're

good and I use them. The last two are mine, and for a beginner working a local market they matter more than the first four.

1. Growing. Are there more of these businesses this year than last? A shrinking market means you're fighting for a smaller pot every quarter.

2. Can afford you. What does one job pay them? A business where the average job is \$180 cannot pay you what a business where the average job is \$4,000 can, no matter how much they like you.

3. Easy to find. Can you build a list of 200 of them in an hour? If they're not on Google Maps, not in a directory, and not in a trade association, you'll spend your time on list-building instead of outreach.

4. In pain. Do they visibly need more customers? Competition is a good sign here, not a bad one. If nobody's advertising in a vertical, that's often because it doesn't work.

5. Can you reach the owner directly? This is the screen nobody talks about and it decides everything early on. In a two-person landscaping company, the owner answers the phone. In a regional chain, you'll spend four weeks getting past a gatekeeper to a marketing manager who has a vendor already. Early on, you want businesses small enough that the person who can say yes is the person who picks up.

6. Does one extra job obviously pay your fee? Do the arithmetic out loud, in their terms. If a roofer closes one in three estimates and a roof is \$9,000 at 30% margin, then one extra estimate a month is roughly \$900 in margin. If you're charging \$500 a month, the math is not a debate — it's arithmetic they can do in their head while you're talking. If you have to build a spreadsheet to justify your fee, pick a different vertical.

THE RADIUS

Set it at twenty to thirty minutes of driving, then stop expanding.

Density beats size. Two hundred qualifying businesses inside twenty minutes is worth more than two thousand spread across the state, for four reasons that compound:

You can show up in person, which almost nobody does anymore. They know the streets you name. One client's referral is likely to be another business in the same radius. And your case study is about a business their customers actually use.

The instinct is to widen the radius when outreach is slow. Resist it. A slow week inside a tight radius is a message problem or a volume problem, and widening the map hides both.

SCORE IT AND MOVE ON

SCREEN	WEIGHT	SCORE 1-5	WEIGHTED
Owner is reachable directly	×3		
One extra job covers your fee	×3		
Can afford you (job value)	×2		
Easy to build a list of 200	×2		
Visibly in pain / already advertising	×2		
Growing category	×1		
You find it tolerable to talk about daily	×1		
Total			/70

Score three verticals. Take the highest. If two are within five points, take the one where you already know somebody — a warm first conversation is worth more than two scorecard points.

The full weighted version, with a worked example, is in the asset vault as **Niche Selection Scorecard**.

That last screen is weighted lowest on purpose, but don't skip it. You're going to talk about this every day for a year. If the category actively bores you, that shows up in your writing and on your calls, and no scorecard can fix it.

Failure modes

You pick by margin alone.

FIX — High-margin verticals are usually the ones every agency already targets. Weight reachability and the fee arithmetic above margin — a slightly less profitable vertical where the owner picks up the phone will make you more money in year one.

You widen the radius when it gets quiet.

FIX — Hold the radius and fix the message instead. Widening the map converts a diagnosable problem into an undiagnosable one.

You pick something you can't get access to.

FIX — Before committing, spend twenty minutes trying to reach three owners in the vertical. If you can't get a human in three tries, that's your answer, and you found it in twenty minutes instead of two months.

You change lanes after four bad weeks.

FIX — Four bad weeks is not a verdict on a market, it's a verdict on 200 attempts. Apply the 300-attempt rule from Chapter 2 before you conclude anything about the vertical.

You pick a vertical with no seasonality awareness.

FIX — Landscaping in January and snow removal in July are different businesses. Check when your vertical's money actually moves, and plan outreach to arrive a month before their season starts, not during it.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Qualifying businesses inside your radius. One number, counted once. Open a map, search your vertical, count what's inside the boundary you drew.

If the answer is under 100, either the radius is too tight or the vertical is too narrow — widen one of them, once, and recount.

If the answer is over 500, you have plenty and the constraint is your daily number, not your market.

What "good" looks like: enough to sustain your daily number for six months without repeating yourself. At 20 attempts a day, five days a week, that's roughly 400 businesses with room for follow-ups. Do that arithmetic with your own number.

DO THIS NOW

45 minutes

Open a map. Draw a twenty-minute radius around where you live.

Pick three service verticals inside it — the ones you'd guess first are fine. Score each one against the seven rows in the table above. Don't research; use what you already believe. The scorecard's job is to make you decide, not to be right.

Take the winner. Write one sentence on a note you'll see tomorrow:

"I sell to [vertical] within [radius]."

Then open the map again and count how many of them there are. That number is your market, and you now have one.

PART TWO

The Offer

What you sell, what you charge for it, and the paper that keeps a good month from turning into a bad year.

STAGES COVERED · **OFFER**

PICK A LANE YOU CAN DRIVE TO

4

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 2 — OFFER

Build the Offer They Say Yes To

By the end of this chapter you'll have one offer, at one price, described in one sentence you can say out loud without flinching.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The first version of your offer and what was wrong with it. What you were selling before you figured out what to sell. The moment a business owner's face changed when you described it differently.

Here's a sentence I hear from beginners constantly, and it loses the deal before the deal starts:

"I do digital marketing for local businesses."

Nobody buys digital marketing. A landscaper doesn't wake up wanting digital marketing. He wakes up wanting his crew booked solid in April so he doesn't have to lay anybody off in May.

The gap between those two sentences is the entire chapter.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Sell the thing they can count. For a local service business, that thing is a booked appointment on their calendar — not leads, not traffic, not marketing.

Why most people get this wrong

Beginners sell inputs. Experienced operators sell outputs.

An input is something you do: run ads, build a funnel, manage social, send emails. An output is something the client gets: a plumber on a job site, an estimate on the calendar, a signed contract.

Selling inputs feels safer because it's what you actually control. If you promise "I'll run your ads," you can always say you ran the ads. But it puts you in a terrible position, because the client has no way to tell whether it worked, which means the only thing they can evaluate is the invoice.

There's a middle version that's almost as bad: selling **leads**. Leads sound like an output but they're not, because "lead" has no agreed definition. You think a lead is a form fill. He thinks a lead is somebody who wants to buy. You deliver forty and he says none of them were real, and you're both right, and now you're arguing.

A booked appointment is the smallest unit both of you will agree happened. That's why it's the thing to sell.

An appointment has a time on it. It's on a calendar. Either a person showed up or they didn't. There's nothing to argue about, which means there's nothing to argue about when the invoice comes either.

The system

1. DEFINE YOUR UNIT OF SALE PRECISELY

Write it down, in the agreement, in the words you'd use with a lawyer standing there.

A weak definition: "qualified leads."

A strong definition: "a scheduled appointment with a decision-maker in your service area who has confirmed the time by text or phone."

The strong one names four things — that it's scheduled, who it's with, where they are, and what confirmation means. Every one of those is a fight you're not having in month three.

2. MAKE THE VALUE OBVIOUS BEFORE YOU SAY THE PRICE

This is where the Value Equation is useful. Alex Hormozi's framing is that an offer's value goes up with the size of the outcome and the buyer's belief it'll work, and down with how long it takes and how much hassle it costs them. It's a good lens. Here's what it looks like applied to a guy with a truck and three employees.

The outcome is not "more customers." It's "six more estimates on your calendar in the next thirty days." Numbers and a timeframe, in his units.

Belief it'll work is the hard one when you're starting out and have no case study. What you have instead is specificity. A person who can describe exactly what will happen — where the leads come from, what the follow-up looks like, what happens when someone doesn't answer — is more believable than a person with a vague promise and a testimonial from an unrelated industry.

Time to result is why Chapter 11 exists. If your setup takes three weeks because you didn't start messaging registration on day one, you've made your own offer worse.

Effort and sacrifice is where most local offers quietly fail. If your system requires the owner to answer his phone within five minutes during a workday, you've handed a roofer on a roof a job he can't do. Build the follow-up so it works when he's holding a nail gun.

3. SCOPE IT HARD

Write down what you don't do. Out loud, in the proposal.

Not because you're being difficult, but because an unbounded offer gets eaten. You'll agree to run appointment generation and four months later you're editing his website, designing a truck wrap, and answering texts about his Google review from a customer who's mad about a hedge.

Every one of those was you being helpful. Together they're the reason your effective hourly rate collapsed.

4. GET IT TO ONE SENTENCE

You should be able to say the whole thing in a breath:

"I put booked estimates on your calendar. You show up to them. You pay me [X] a month plus a one-time setup."

If it takes you two minutes to explain what you do, you'll lose people in the first thirty seconds of every conversation you ever have.

The asset

OFFER BUILDER — FILL THIS IN BEFORE YOUR NEXT CALL

1. WHO

I sell to _____ within _____ minutes of _____.

2. THE UNIT

I deliver: _____

Defined precisely as: _____

3. THE OUTCOME, IN THEIR UNITS

_____ [unit] in the first _____ days.

4. WHAT ONE UNIT IS WORTH TO THEM

Average job value: \$ _____

Their close rate: _____%

Value of one appointment: \$ _____ (job value x close rate)

5. TIME TO FIRST RESULT

Registration + build: _____ days

First appointment by: day _____

6. WHAT I DO NOT DO

7. THE ONE SENTENCE

Full version with a worked example: **Offer Builder Worksheet** in the asset vault.

WATCH YOUR LANGUAGE

Describing an outcome is fine. Guaranteeing an income is not. "Six booked estimates in thirty days" is a service commitment you can define and meet. "This will make you \$40,000" is a prediction about someone else's business that you don't control — and in Massachusetts, a promise like that in a proposal is exposure under c. 93A, which carries treble damages for business-to-business claims. Chapter 6 covers this properly.

Failure modes

You sell "leads" and end up arguing about what one is.

FIX — Switch the unit to a booked, confirmed appointment and write the definition into the agreement. Do it before the first invoice, not after the first argument.

Your offer needs the owner to behave like an office worker.

FIX — Rebuild the follow-up so it runs without him. If your system dies when he's on a roof for six hours, it dies in week one.

You promise a volume you can't hit in a small market.

FIX — Count the addressable businesses and estimate demand before you commit to a number. Promising twenty appointments a month in a town where the vertical does forty jobs a month is a refund you've already agreed to.

Scope grows one favor at a time.

FIX — Keep a written list of out-of-scope requests. When it hits three, that's a conversation about a second engagement, not four more favors.

You have three offers and pitch whichever seems to fit.

FIX — Run one offer until you've sold it ten times. Three offers means you never get good at explaining any of them, and you can't tell which one the market actually wanted.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Offer-to-close rate. Of the people who heard your full offer and price, how many bought?

This is different from your reply rate or your booking rate. It isolates the offer itself, which is the only way to know whether the problem is your offer or your outreach.

What "good" looks like: a rate that improves as you say it more. And a caution worth remembering — if you're closing more than half the people who hear your price, the offer is probably fine and the price is probably low. Chapter 5 deals with that.

DO THIS NOW

40 minutes

Fill in the seven fields of the offer builder above for the vertical you picked in Chapter 3. Guess where you have to — you'll correct it after five real conversations.

Then do the one thing that actually matters: **say the one-sentence version out loud, ten times.**

Not in your head. Out loud, in a room. It will feel ridiculous. It will also be the difference between sounding like someone who has a business and someone who is reading.

If you stumble over the same phrase twice, that phrase is wrong. Rewrite it and say it ten more times.

5

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 2 — OFFER

Price Against the Job, Not the Competition

By the end of this chapter you'll price from what one closed job is worth to your client, split your fee to match how value actually arrives, and know the signal that says you're too cheap.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

What you charged the first client. What you charge now. And the specific moment you raised your price — did you sweat it, what did you say, and what happened?

Almost every beginner prices the same way, and it's the worst of the three available methods.

They look at what other agencies charge, land somewhere slightly under it, and call that competitive.

Think about what that actually is. You've set your price using information about somebody else's business — their costs, their team, their market, their overhead — none of which you know and none of which applies to you. You've copied a number off a stranger's homework.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Price from what one closed job is worth to the client. Their arithmetic sets your ceiling. Your costs and your competitors are irrelevant to them.

Why most people get this wrong

There are three ways to set a price, and they're worth naming because most people use one by accident. This framing comes from Alex Hormozi's pricing work, and it's the clearest version I've seen.

Cost-plus is your costs plus a margin. It's simple and it's wrong here, because your client has no idea what it costs you and wouldn't care if he did. Your software bill is not his problem.

Competitor-based is the copying described above. It's the most common and the most damaging, because it caps you at whatever the least ambitious agency in your market decided to charge.

Value-based is pricing against what the outcome is worth to the buyer. It takes more thinking and it's the only one that scales.

Here's why the third one matters so much in local service. The gap between what an appointment costs you to produce and what it's worth to the client is enormous, and it's enormous in a way that's provable to him in about fifteen seconds.

DO THE ARITHMETIC IN HIS UNITS

Sit with a roofer. Ask two questions.

"What's an average job worth to you?" Say \$9,000.

"Out of every three estimates you go out on, how many turn into work?" Say one.

So one estimate is worth \$3,000 in revenue to him on average. At a 30% margin, roughly \$900 in his pocket.

Now you say your price. If you're charging \$1,500 a month and delivering six estimates, you've put roughly \$5,400 of margin on his calendar for \$1,500. That's not a negotiation. That's arithmetic he just did in his head while you were talking.

If you have to build a spreadsheet to justify your fee, your price is wrong or your vertical is wrong. The good version fits in one breath.

Notice what happened there. You never mentioned what other agencies charge. You never mentioned your costs. You anchored on his numbers, which he trusts, because he gave them to you.

The system

1. SPLIT THE FEE TO MATCH HOW THE VALUE ARRIVES

This is the highest-value idea in the chapter and almost nobody starting out does it.

You deliver two different kinds of value, and they arrive on completely different schedules.

One-time value: the build. Registration, the account, the pipeline, the automations, the calendar, the follow-up sequences. That work has a beginning and an end, and its value lands once, up front.

Ongoing value: running it. Managing spend, adjusting messaging, handling replies, reporting, fixing what breaks. That value arrives continuously in small amounts.

If you bundle both into one monthly number, two bad things happen. Your build gets underpriced, because a month of management doesn't feel like it should cost what three weeks of setup costs. And your retainer gets overpriced relative to what shows up each month, which makes you fragile.

So: a one-time setup fee for the build, and a smaller monthly fee for the management.

WHAT YOU'RE CHARGING FOR	SHAPE	WHY
Registration, account build, automations, sequences	One-time setup fee	Value lands once. Paid before the work, which also filters out non-buyers
Management, optimization, replies, reporting	Monthly retainer	Value arrives continuously and should be judged continuously
Ad spend	Paid by client, direct to platform	Never run this through your account. It inflates your revenue, wrecks your margins, and makes you a bank

2. UNDERSTAND THE LOOKBACK WINDOW

Here's something that took me a while to see, and it explains most agency churn.

Clients don't judge you across the relationship. They judge you across the last billing cycle.

You can deliver a spectacular January. If March is quiet, the conversation in April is about March. The January result doesn't carry forward the way you think it should — in his head, January was paid for by January's invoice.

This has two consequences. Report every single month, even a bad one, so the window always has something in it. And bill on the longest cycle your client will accept, because a longer cycle gives you a longer window to be judged over.

3. THREE TIERS, NAMED FOR WHAT THEY GET

Different clients have genuinely different budgets, and one price leaves money on both ends. But three tiers only work if the buyer can tell instantly which one is his.

	STARTER	STANDARD	FULL
Setup	\$___ one-time	\$___ one-time	\$___ one-time
Monthly	\$___	\$___	\$___
Channels	One	Two	Two + retargeting
Follow-up	Automated	Automated + manual	Automated + manual + call
Reporting	Monthly	Weekly	Weekly + call
Best for	Solo operator	2-5 crew	Multi-crew or multi-location

That last row does more work than the prices do. Name the buyer, not the feature.

The calculator with the underlying logic is in the asset vault as **Three-Tier Pricing Calculator**.

4. READ THE SIGNALS THAT SAY YOU'RE TOO CHEAP

Two of them, and both are counterintuitive because they feel like success.

You're closing more than half the people who hear your price. A high close rate feels great and usually means you're leaving money on the table. If nearly everyone says yes, the number isn't testing anything.

You're at capacity. If you can't take another client, price is the only lever you have left. Raising it is not greed at that point, it's arithmetic — you physically cannot sell more hours.

Raising prices does two things at once, which is why it's so powerful. You make more per client, and you serve fewer clients for the same revenue, which cuts your delivery cost. Both sides move in your favor.

The cost is that you'll hear no more often. That's the trade, and it's a good one — but it's an emotional cost, not a financial one, and people quietly reverse good price increases because hearing no is unpleasant.

Failure modes

You bundle setup into the monthly and underprice the build.

FIX — Split them. The build has a start and an end; charge for it once, up front, before the work begins.

You run client ad spend through your own card.

FIX — Have the client put their own card on the ad platform from day one. Fronting spend turns you into an unsecured lender to a small business, and you will eventually meet the client who doesn't pay.

You discount to close instead of adjusting scope.

FIX — If the price is too high, remove something — a channel, a reporting cadence, manual follow-up. Cutting price with scope unchanged teaches the client that your number was fiction.

You raise prices on new clients and never on existing ones.

FIX — Put a modest annual adjustment in the agreement from the start, so it's a term they agreed to rather than a conversation you have to nerve yourself up for.

You take a client who can't afford the outcome.

FIX — If one extra job doesn't obviously cover your fee, no price works. That's a lane problem, not a pricing problem — go back to Chapter 3.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Close rate at the current price. Track it per price point, not overall. When you raise a price, the number you care about is total revenue collected, not the percentage who said yes.

Average revenue per client, first 90 days. Setup plus three months. This is the number that tells you whether your pricing structure works, because it captures both halves of the split.

What "good" looks like: a close rate low enough that you're occasionally losing on price. If you never lose a deal on price, you have never found your ceiling — and you can't know what you're leaving behind.

DO THIS NOW

35 minutes

Find one business in your chosen vertical, on Google, in your radius.

Work out their arithmetic from public information and reasonable estimates. What does a job cost? Search it. How many estimates does a business like that likely close? Ask anyone you know in the trade, or estimate one in three.

Write down: **value of one appointment to this business = job value × close rate.**

Now write your setup fee and your monthly next to it, and check whether the ratio is obvious. If a business owner would need convincing rather than a calculator, adjust one of the two numbers until the arithmetic speaks for itself.

Keep this page. It's the first slide of every pitch you'll ever give.

6

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 2 — OFFER

Paper That Protects You

By the end of this chapter you'll know what every clause in your agreement is actually preventing, and why Massachusetts makes a careless proposal more expensive than most places.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

A scope dispute, a late payment, or a client who wanted more than what was agreed. What happened, what the agreement did or didn't say, and what you changed afterward.

READ THIS BEFORE THE CHAPTER

I am not a lawyer. Nothing in this chapter or in the templates in the asset vault is legal advice, and reading it doesn't create any kind of attorney-client relationship. Every template here is a starting point for a conversation with a licensed attorney in your own state — not a document to sign as-is. Laws differ by state and they change. Get it reviewed. It costs less than you think and enormously less than the thing it prevents.

Most people starting out work off a screenshot of a proposal they found in a Facebook group, or nothing at all.

Nothing at all is more common than you'd guess. A text message that says "sounds good, let's start Monday" is how a real percentage of local agency work begins.

That works fine right up until it doesn't, and when it doesn't, you find out that every ambiguity you left in gets resolved against you — because the other person's memory of what you agreed is genuinely different from yours, and neither of you is lying.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Every clause in your agreement exists because someone, somewhere, had that exact argument. You're not being formal. You're borrowing other people's scar tissue.

Why most people get this wrong

Two failures, opposite directions.

Too little paper. A handshake and an invoice. Feels fast and friendly. The problem isn't that your client is dishonest — most aren't. The problem is that "you'll handle my marketing" means different things to the two of you, and you won't discover the gap until month three when he asks why his website isn't done.

Too much paper, copied blind. Someone downloads a fourteen-page agency contract written for a firm with eleven employees and sends it to a guy with a truck. He doesn't read it, he feels talked down to, and half the clauses don't apply. Worse, you can't explain your own document, which is the real failure — if a client asks what a clause means and you don't know, you've lost more trust than the clause was protecting.

You should be able to explain every clause in your own agreement in one sentence, without notes. If you can't, take it out or learn it.

The system

TWO DOCUMENTS, NOT ONE

The MSA — Master Services Agreement. The rules of the relationship. Signed once. Payment terms, liability, confidentiality, IP ownership, what happens when someone wants out. This doesn't change per client.

The SOW — Statement of Work. What you're actually doing, for how much, over what period. One per engagement. Short. This is the document that changes.

Splitting them means you can add a second engagement, or change scope, without reopening the whole relationship. You write a new SOW and the MSA keeps governing.

THE CLAUSES THAT MATTER, AND WHAT EACH ONE PREVENTS

CLAUSE	WHAT IT PREVENTS
Scope, stated positively and negatively	The four-month drift where you're editing his website. List what's included and what isn't. The exclusions do more work than the inclusions
Definition of the deliverable	The "these leads aren't real" argument. Define a booked appointment precisely — scheduled, with a decision-maker, in the service area, confirmed how
Client responsibilities	Being blamed for a failure that was theirs. If they must respond to appointments within a set time, provide access, or supply their own card for ad spend — write it down
Payment terms and late fees	Sixty-day invoices. State the due date, the method, and what happens when it's late
Ad spend handling	Becoming your client's lender. State plainly that spend is billed by the platform to the client's own payment method
Term, renewal, and notice	The 11pm text that says "we're done." An initial term with a defined notice period gives both sides a runway
Termination for cause, both ways	Being trapped with a client who won't pay or won't cooperate. Make it mutual — it's fairer and it's easier to sign
Ownership of accounts and assets	The ugliest fight in this business. Say who owns the ad account, the phone number, the CRM sub-account, and the data on the way out. Decide it while everyone's happy
Limitation of liability	A \$1,500/month engagement producing a claim for lost business. Typically capped at fees paid — have your attorney set this
Confidentiality	Arguments about their customer data. Also required if you're touching contact lists
Compliance and consent	Liability for their list. If they hand you contacts to message, say who is responsible for having obtained consent — see Chapter 17
No guarantee of results	The claim that you promised revenue. Describe the service you'll perform, never the income they'll earn
Annual adjustment	Being stuck at year-one pricing in year three. A modest stated adjustment is far easier agreed at signing than raised later

MASSACHUSETTS MAKES THIS SHARPER

If you're operating here, one statute deserves your attention: **Massachusetts General Laws chapter 93A**.

93A prohibits unfair or deceptive acts in trade or commerce. Most people know it as a consumer protection law — that's section 9. The one that matters to you is **section 11, which covers business-to-business claims**. Your client is a business. That's the section you live under.

What makes it sharp is the remedy. Where a violation was willful or knowing, or where a party refused to settle in bad faith after a written demand, a court can award **up to treble damages plus the other side's attorney's fees**.

Sit with that for a second. In a dispute over a \$1,500-a-month engagement, the fees can dwarf the amount in dispute.

So the practical instruction is simple and it costs you nothing:

Describe the service. Never predict their income.

"Six booked estimates a month" is a service commitment you define and meet.

"This will add \$40,000 to your year" is a prediction about a business you don't control, and if it doesn't happen, you've handed someone a sentence to point at.

THE SAME RULE PROTECTS YOUR CLIENTS

This isn't only about you. Your clients are going to run ads, collect reviews, and make claims to their own customers — and the FTC's Endorsement Guides, revised in July 2023, require testimonial claims to be truthful and to represent typical results, with material connections disclosed clearly and conspicuously. If you write ad copy that overstates, you've built your client's exposure. Chapter 17 covers this in full.

GET IT REVIEWED ONCE

One session with a Massachusetts business attorney to review an MSA and SOW template you'll reuse for every client is among the best money you'll spend in year one. You're not buying a document — you're buying a reviewed template that serves fifty engagements.

Bring a draft. Attorneys charge less to fix something than to originate it.

The asset

Three templates in the vault, each carrying the same header:

MSA Skeleton · SOW Skeleton · Proposal Template

TEMPLATE ONLY — NOT LEGAL ADVICE.
Review with a licensed attorney in your state before use.
Bracketed items [LIKE THIS] must be completed or removed.
This template has not been reviewed by counsel for your jurisdiction, your business, or your engagement.

Each clause in the templates carries a plain-English annotation saying what it protects, so you can explain your own paper.

Failure modes

You start work before anything is signed.

FIX — Signature and setup fee first, work second. No exceptions, including for the friend-of-a-friend — especially for the friend-of-a-friend.

Your agreement doesn't say who owns the accounts.

FIX — Add the ownership clause today and apply it to existing clients at renewal. This is the fight that ends relationships badly, and it's completely avoidable.

A results promise sneaks into the proposal.

FIX — Search every document you send for the words guarantee, will make, and ROI. Rewrite each one as a description of the service you'll perform.

You use a template you can't explain.

FIX — Read your own agreement start to finish and write a one-sentence explanation beside each clause. Anything you can't explain gets removed or understood — there is no third option.

You message a list the client handed you without asking where it came from.

FIX — Put consent responsibility in writing, and ask how the list was collected before you send anything. Their list becomes your problem the moment you press send.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Percentage of active clients under a current signed agreement. The target is 100%, and if it isn't, you already know which client you're thinking about.

Days from proposal sent to signature. A number that climbs usually means the proposal is doing too much explaining, not that clients got slower.

What "good" looks like: every client on paper, every paper reviewed once by an attorney, and no document in circulation containing a sentence about how much money the client will make.

DO THIS NOW

30 minutes

Open every document you currently send a prospect — proposal, email template, pitch deck, the note in your phone.

Search for four things: **guarantee**, **will make**, **ROI**, and **promise**.

Rewrite every hit as a description of what you'll do rather than what they'll earn. "We'll deliver six booked estimates a month" instead of "you'll add \$40k a year."

Then open a calendar and book thirty minutes with a business attorney in your state for the MSA and SOW review. Booking it is the task. Do that part today, because it's the one you'll otherwise put off for a year.

PAPER THAT PROTECTS YOU

PART THREE

The Acquisition Engine

The unglamorous middle of the business: how strangers become conversations, and conversations become signatures.

STAGES COVERED · **VOLUME** · **CLOSE**

PAPER THAT PROTECTS YOU

7

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 3 — VOLUME

The Daily Number

By the end of this chapter you'll run a repeatable outreach day inside a pipeline instead of a notebook, and know within a week whether it's working.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

What an actual day looked like while you were doing all three — class, lifts, practice, film, and the agency. Where the outreach physically happened. The time on the clock. What you gave up to fit it in.

Chapter 2 was about the commitment. This one is about the machinery, because a daily number you can't execute cleanly turns into a daily number you stop hitting.

The difference between someone who does 20 attempts a day for six months and someone who intends to is almost never discipline. It's friction. If sitting down to do outreach requires you to first decide who to contact, find their number, remember whether you already messaged them, and figure out what to say — you've built a job that takes an hour of setup before any work happens.

Nobody sustains that. So we remove it.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Build the list before you need it, and track every touch outside your head. Your memory of how much outreach you did is always wrong, in whichever direction is least useful.

Why most people get this wrong

They treat outreach as an activity instead of a system, and it shows up in three ways.

They build the list and do outreach in the same session. Two hours blocked, ninety minutes finding businesses, thirty minutes messaging. It feels like a productive afternoon. It's 30 minutes of work.

They track in their head or in a notes app. Which means they don't know who they've contacted, when, or how many times. So they either double-message people, which is embarrassing, or they never follow up, which is where most of the results live.

They quit on someone after one attempt. This is the big one. Most people stop after the first try. The reply you were going to get was often on attempt four.

The follow-up is not the annoying part of outreach. The follow-up is the outreach. The first message just starts the clock.

The system

1. BUILD THE LIST ON A DIFFERENT DAY THAN YOU WORK IT

Batch it. One session a week — an hour, maybe two — where you do nothing but add businesses to the list.

For a local service vertical, your sources are boring and effective. Google Maps searched by town, one town at a time. Trade association directories. The town's business listing. Facebook groups for the area. Driving around with your phone, which sounds ridiculous and works, because a truck with a phone number on it is a lead nobody else in your market is collecting.

What you need per business: name, owner's name if you can get it, phone, email if available, one specific detail. That last field matters more than the rest — it's what makes the first line of your message not sound like a blast.

2. SIX PIPELINE STAGES, NO MORE

In GoHighLevel or whatever you use, build one pipeline for outreach with these stages:

STAGE	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT MOVES IT FORWARD
Cold	On the list, never contacted	First touch sent
Touched	Contacted, no response yet	Any reply, or exhausting the sequence
Replied	Responded, including "not interested"	A real back-and-forth
Conversa- tion	Engaged past the first exchange	Call scheduled
Call Booked	Time on the calendar	Call happens
Proposal Out	They've heard the price	Signature or a no

Six stages you'll actually maintain beats twelve you'll abandon in a fortnight. And every one of these is countable, which means at any moment you can answer "where is this actually breaking?"

That question is the whole reason for the pipeline. A month from now you'll have a bad week, and the difference between "outreach isn't working" and "I have 40 in Replied and 2 in Call Booked, so my problem is the transition to a call" is the difference between panic and a fix.

3. SEQUENCE THE FOLLOW-UP, DON'T IMPROVISE IT

Decide in advance how many touches a business gets before you stop, and on what schedule. Write it once. Then it's not a decision you make while tired.

A reasonable shape for local service, spread across roughly two weeks: first touch, then a follow-up a day or two later, then a couple more spaced out across the following week, then a final one. Five to seven touches total, front-loaded.

Vary the channel. If you emailed first, the second touch can be a call. The third can be a different angle entirely rather than a nudge on the same one.

Then move them to a long-term list rather than deleting them. A landscaper who ignored you in February may be desperate in April. Nothing about your business changed — his season did.

BEFORE ANY OF THIS TOUCHES SMS

Text messaging to businesses through an application — which is what your CRM is — requires A2P 10DLC registration. Since February 2025, US carriers block unregistered traffic. Not throttle. Block. If SMS is in your sequence, read Chapter 11 and start registration before you build any of this, because it runs on carrier time, not yours.

4. RUN THE DAY THE SAME WAY EVERY TIME

Open the pipeline. Work the Touched column first — follow-ups before new contacts, always, because follow-ups convert better and they're the thing you'll skip if you leave them last.

Then new contacts from Cold until you hit your number.

Then log. Three tallies: attempts, replies, conversations.

Close it. Don't check it again at 11pm. The number is done or it isn't, and refreshing your inbox is not outreach.

The asset

THE OUTREACH DAY — A REPEATABLE BLOCK

BEFORE THE BLOCK (once a week, separate session)

- ☐ Add 100+ businesses to Cold
- ☐ Each row: name, owner, phone, email, one specific detail

THE BLOCK (same time daily)

- ☐ Work Touched: every follow-up due today
- ☐ Work Cold: new contacts until the number is hit
- ☐ Move anyone who replied into Replied
- ☐ Log: attempts ___ replies ___ conversations ___
- ☐ Close it

WEEKLY (4 minutes, Sunday)

- ☐ Total the three columns
- ☐ Reply rate = replies / attempts
- ☐ Count what is sitting in each pipeline stage
- ☐ Name the single biggest drop-off. That is next week's problem.

Full version: **Outreach Pipeline Spec** in the asset vault.

Failure modes

List-building eats the outreach block.

FIX — Separate sessions on separate days. If you're finding businesses during the outreach block, you're not doing outreach.

You do first touches and skip follow-ups.

FIX — Work the Touched column before the Cold column, every single day. New contacts are more fun and less productive.

Your pipeline has fourteen stages and nobody updates it.

FIX — Cut back to six. A pipeline that's out of date is worse than no pipeline, because you'll trust it and it'll be wrong.

You delete the no-replies.

FIX — Move them to a long-term list with a date to revisit. Seasonality does more of your selling than your message does.

Everything piles up in one stage and you don't notice.

FIX — Count the stages weekly. Forty in Replied and two in Call Booked is a specific, fixable problem — but only if you look.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Stage-to-stage conversion. Cold to Touched, Touched to Replied, Replied to Conversation, Conversation to Call Booked, Call Booked to Proposal Out.

This is the real diagnostic in the whole book. Every stage-to-stage number points at a different fix. Weak Touched-to-Replied means your message or targeting. Strong replies but weak conversations means your opener is interesting and your offer isn't. Plenty of conversations but few calls booked means you're not asking for the call directly enough.

What "good" looks like: your own numbers from last month. Nothing else. Published benchmarks come from other people's lists in other people's markets, and the only honest comparison is against yourself.

DO THIS NOW

45 minutes

Build the pipeline. Six stages, exactly as named above, in whatever CRM you're using. If you don't have one yet, a spreadsheet with a Stage column is completely adequate for your first hundred.

Then spend the remaining time adding businesses to Cold from the vertical and radius you picked in Chapter 3. Name, owner, phone, and one specific detail per row.

Target 40 rows. If you get 25, that's fine — you have a list, which is more than you had this morning, and tomorrow's block now has somewhere to start.

8

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 3 — VOLUME

Scripts That Don't Sound Like Scripts

By the end of this chapter you'll understand the anatomy underneath a message that gets answered, and you'll have written your own in four channels.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The first message that ever got a reply. Pasted exactly as sent, typos and all. What you were expecting, what came back, and what you learned about why it worked.

AUTHOR NOTE — THIS CHAPTER NEEDS ISAIAH'S REAL SCRIPTS

The anatomy below is teaching, and it stands. But the fill-in-the-blank versions are structures, not proven messages. Before publication, replace each with Isaiah's actual message — the one that produced replies — and label it as his. A structure the reader fills in is honest and useful. A structure presented as a proven script is neither.

I'm going to give you the anatomy before I give you anything to copy, because the anatomy is the part that transfers and the copy isn't.

Every message that ever gets answered is doing the same four things in the same order, whether it's a DM or a walk-in. Once you can see the four, you can write your own for any channel, and you'll stop needing scripts.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

A cold message earns a reply by proving you looked. Everything else — the offer, the credentials, the pitch — is worthless until that's established in the first line.

Why most people get this wrong

Beginners write about themselves.

"Hi, my name is ___ and I run a digital marketing agency helping local businesses grow with proven strategies."

Read that as a landscaper with 400 unread emails. Nothing in it is about him. Nothing in it proves the sender knows he exists. It could have been sent to ten thousand people because it was.

The reason this happens is that you're nervous and credentials feel like armor. So you lead with who you are, because you're trying to establish that you're legitimate.

But legitimacy isn't what's blocking the reply. **Being ignored is what's blocking the reply.** And you don't beat being ignored with credentials — you beat it by being visibly not-a-blast.

The second mistake is asking for too much. A cold message that ends in "do you have 15 minutes for a call this week?" is asking a stranger to give up a chunk of their day before they know what this is. The first ask should be tiny.

The goal of the first message is not a call. It's a reply. Any reply. Once someone has written back once, you're in a conversation, and conversations are a completely different game than cold contact.

The system

THE FOUR-PART ANATOMY

1. Proof you looked. One specific, checkable detail about their business. Not "I love your work." Something you could only know by looking — a truck you saw, the town they serve, a job on their feed, the fact they're booked out, the fact their website has no way to request a quote.

This is the whole first line and it does 80% of the work.

2. The observation. One sentence connecting that detail to a problem or an opportunity. Not a pitch. An observation. You're demonstrating that you understand their business, not selling yet.

3. What you do, in one line, in their units. Booked estimates. Booked jobs. Filled calendar. Not "marketing," not "lead generation," not "growth."

4. A tiny ask. A yes/no question that costs nothing to answer. "Worth a look?" "Want me to send it?" "Are you taking new work in April?"

That's it. Four moves. Two to four sentences total.

WHAT EACH CHANNEL CHANGES

The anatomy stays. The length and tone shift.

CHANNEL	LENGTH	WHAT'S DIFFERENT
Instagram / Facebook DM	2-3 sentences	Most casual. Their feed gives you the specific detail for free. No greeting block, no signature — write like a person texting
Email	4-5 sentences	Subject line does the work of part 1. Lowercase, specific, no pitch. Keep the body under what fits on a phone screen without scrolling
Cold call	15 seconds to the ask	Name the reason you're calling immediately. Give them a clean exit — it lowers defenses and gets you a real answer instead of a brush-off
Walk-in	30 seconds	Your biggest edge and nobody does it. Go at a slow hour. Ask for the owner by name. Leave something physical

ON THE WALK-IN

I want to make a case for this, because it's the channel most people skip and it's the one where a young local operator has an actual advantage.

An agency three time zones away cannot walk into a landscaping office in your town on a Tuesday morning. You can. You know the streets. You can name the intersection. And the owner is a real person who is far more likely to give thirty seconds of attention to someone standing in front of him than to a name in his spam folder.

It's uncomfortable. That's most of why it works — the discomfort is exactly what keeps the channel uncrowded.

Go at a slow hour for their trade. Ask for the owner by name, which requires having looked him up, which is itself the proof-you-looked step. Say the four-part message. Leave one page and get out. Three minutes.

THE STRUCTURES

REPLACE WITH ISAIAH'S ACTUAL MESSAGES BEFORE PUBLICATION

Below are the four-part structures, written as fill-in templates. They are anatomically correct and they are not proven copy. Each should be swapped for the real version that produced replies, kept in Isaiah's own wording.

DM — STRUCTURE

[SPECIFIC DETAIL — something only visible by looking at their page, truck, site, or listing.]

[ONE-LINE OBSERVATION connecting that detail to a problem or a window of opportunity. No pitch.]

[WHAT YOU DO, in their units — booked estimates, filled calendar.]

[TINY ASK — a yes/no question.]

EMAIL — STRUCTURE

subject: [lowercase, specific to them, no pitch]

[SPECIFIC DETAIL.]

[OBSERVATION — one or two sentences.]

[WHAT YOU DO, one line, in their units.]

[TINY ASK.]

[First name]

COLD CALL — OPENER STRUCTURE

"Hey [NAME], this is [YOUR NAME] — I'm local, over in [TOWN].

This is a cold call, so I'll be quick.

[SPECIFIC DETAIL + OBSERVATION, one breath.]

[WHAT YOU DO, one line.]

Is that something you'd want to hear about, or should I
leave you alone?"

Naming the cold call as a cold call is deliberate. It disarms the thing they're already thinking, and the explicit exit at the end gets you a real answer rather than a polite dodge — which is worth more, because a fast no is a cheap no.

TWO RULES BEFORE YOU SEND ANYTHING

SMS requires registration. Cold texting through a CRM without A2P 10DLC registration means your messages are blocked outright, not delivered slowly. Chapter 11.

Recorded calls in Massachusetts. If you record calls, M.G.L. c. 272 § 99 applies to any recording made in-state. The statute turns on secrecy — announce it at the top and you're compliant. It's a felony if you don't. Chapter 17 covers it, and Chapter 9 puts the announcement in the script where it belongs.

Failure modes

Your first line is about you.

FIX — Delete the first sentence of every message you've written and see whether it still works. It usually does, and it's usually better.

The "specific detail" is generic praise.

FIX — "Love your work" is not a detail. If the sentence could be sent to any business in the vertical, it isn't proof you looked and it does nothing.

You ask for a call in the first message.

FIX — Ask a yes/no question instead. Get the reply first; the call is what you ask for after they've written back once.

You personalize so heavily you can only send six a day.

FIX — One specific detail is enough. Research beyond that is procrastination wearing a productive costume — the number still has to get hit.

You judge a script on twenty sends.

FIX — Three hundred, per Chapter 2. Twenty sends tells you nothing except how you felt about sending twenty.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Reply rate by channel. Track them separately — a message that works in a DM often dies in email, and averaging them hides which channel is carrying you.

Positive reply rate. Of the people who wrote back, how many were open rather than telling you to go away? A high reply rate made mostly of annoyance means your targeting is off, not your writing.

What "good" looks like: better than your last 300. Then better than that.

DO THIS NOW

40 minutes

Pick five businesses off the Cold list you built in Chapter 7.

For each one, spend three minutes finding a single specific, checkable detail. Write it in the row.

Then write five messages — one per business — following the four-part anatomy. Not five copies of one message. Five messages that share a skeleton and differ in the first line.

Read each one out loud before you send it. If it sounds like something you'd say to a person, send it. If it sounds like something a company would say, rewrite the first line and read it again.

Then send all five.

SCRIPTS THAT DON'T SOUND LIKE SCRIPTS

9

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 4 — CLOSE

The Discovery Call

By the end of this chapter you'll run a call that diagnoses before it pitches and ends in a decision instead of "let me think about it."

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

A call that went badly. What you did wrong, what the owner said, and the specific thing you changed afterward. The worse it went, the better the chapter opens.

The most common way to lose a deal on a discovery call is to start selling in the first two minutes.

You've worked for weeks to get this call. The adrenaline is up. The prospect says "so what do you guys do?" — and you tell him. Fully. For four minutes. With enthusiasm.

And you've just lost, because you pitched a solution to a problem you haven't identified yet, in front of a man who now knows you're here to sell rather than to understand. Everything after that is him being polite.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Diagnose before you prescribe. A price quoted before you understand their problem is a number. A price quoted after is a solution.

Why most people get this wrong

Three reasons, and they're all understandable.

Nerves. Silence is uncomfortable and talking fills it. So you fill it with your own material.

You think the call is your audition. It isn't. The call is your diagnosis. He already decided you were worth thirty minutes — that part's done.

Nobody taught you what to ask. Most people can name what they sell but couldn't list ten questions that would tell them whether this person should buy. So they default to presenting.

Here's the reframe that fixes all three at once. **You are not on this call to convince him. You are on it to find out whether this is going to work.** Some of these people you should not take. A call run as a diagnosis lets you find that out; a call run as a pitch doesn't.

The person asking the questions is running the call. If he's asking and you're answering, you're not selling — you're being interviewed.

The system

BEFORE: FIVE MINUTES OF HOMEWORK

Look at the business. Their site, their reviews, their social, whether there's an obvious way for a customer to request a quote. Write down two things you noticed and one guess about their constraint.

That's it. Five minutes, so you walk in with something specific.

THE CALL, IN SIX MOVES

1. Frame it (30 seconds). Say how long it'll take, what you're going to do, and what happens at the end. And if you're recording, say so here.

OPENING FRAME

"Thanks for making time. Quick heads up, I record these so I can go back through my notes — that alright with you?

So here's how I run these. About twenty minutes. I'm going to ask you a bunch of questions about how you're getting work right now, because I don't know yet whether I can help you.

At the end, one of two things happens. Either I think I can help and I'll tell you exactly what that looks like and what it costs — or I don't, and I'll tell you that too and point you somewhere better. Either way you'll know today.

Sound good?"

That last part does a lot of work. You've told him a no is on the table, which means you're not desperate. And you've said he'll get an answer today, which quietly rules out "let me think about it."

THE RECORDING LINE IS NOT OPTIONAL IN MASSACHUSETTS

M.G.L. c. 272 § 99 makes it a felony to secretly record a call — up to five years and a \$10,000 fine. The operative word in the statute is "secretly." Announce it at the top and get an acknowledgment, and you're on the right side of it. Massachusetts law governs recordings made in-state regardless of where the other party is sitting, and the federal one-party-consent rule doesn't save you. If you'd rather not deal with it, don't record. But don't record quietly.

2. Current state. How work actually arrives today. Get specifics, not categories.

3. The gap. What they want that isn't happening. Quantify it.

4. What they've tried. This is the most valuable section and most people skip it. It tells you what objections are coming, what they've been burned by, and what words to avoid.

5. Cost of doing nothing. If this stays the same for another year, what does that cost? Let him say it. If you say it, it's a pitch; if he says it, it's a fact.

6. Prescribe, then price, then ask. Now — and only now — you tell him what you'd do, what it costs, and you ask for the decision.

THE QUESTION BANK

DISCOVERY QUESTIONS — ASK IN THIS ORDER

CURRENT STATE

- How do people find you right now?
- Where did your last five jobs come from?
- How many estimates do you go out on in a normal week?
- Out of ten estimates, how many turn into work?
- What's an average job worth to you?
- Who answers the phone when someone calls?
- What happens if someone fills out your form at 8pm?

THE GAP

- How many more jobs a week could you actually handle?
- What's stopping you from being there now?
- What does your calendar look like eight weeks out?
- When's your busy season, and when does the phone go quiet?

WHAT THEY'VE TRIED

- Have you worked with a marketing company before?
- What happened?
- What did you like about it? What made you stop?
- What are you doing yourself right now to get work?
- What's the last thing you tried that didn't work?

COST OF DOING NOTHING

- If it's the same twelve months from now, what does that cost you?
- Have you had to turn work down? Or lay anyone off?
- What would three more jobs a month change for you?

DECISION

- If we did this, who else is in on the decision?
- What would need to be true for you to say yes today?

The last two are not throwaway. "Who else is in on the decision" asked at minute fifteen saves you the call where a spouse or a partner appears out of nowhere at the end.

ASK FOR THE DECISION

Then stop talking. This is the hardest sentence in the chapter to actually do.

THE CLOSE

"So based on what you told me — [restate his gap in his own words] — here's what I'd do. [The offer, thirty seconds.]

That's [setup] to build it and [monthly] to run it.

Do you want to do it?"

Then silence. Let it be uncomfortable. Whoever speaks first loses the point, and if you fill the gap you'll fill it with a discount.

BOOK THE NEXT THING BEFORE YOU HANG UP

If it's not a yes today, do not end on "I'll follow up." That's how deals evaporate.

Get the next meeting on the calendar while you're both live. This idea comes from Sharran Srivatsaa via Alex Hormozi's lead nurture work, and it's called booking a meeting from a meeting. Somebody being vague about the next step is an objection, not a scheduling problem — handle it like one.

Failure modes

You pitch in the first three minutes.

FIX — When he asks what you do, answer in one sentence and return a question. "I put booked estimates on contractors' calendars. Before I get into it — how are people finding you right now?"

You skip what they've tried before.

FIX — Ask it every time. A prospect burned by a previous agency has objections you can address before they surface, and you'll only know if you ask.

You quote a price and keep talking.

FIX — Say the number and stop. Practice the silence — it's a physical skill, and it's worth more than any script in this book.

You let the call end without a next date.

FIX — Open the calendar on the call. "I'll follow up" means it's over and neither of you has said so.

You never disqualify anybody.

FIX — If nobody fails your call, you aren't diagnosing. Taking a client whose arithmetic doesn't work costs you more than the revenue — it costs you the two months you spend failing to deliver.

You record without saying so.

FIX — Say the line. In Massachusetts this is a felony statute, not a formality, and it takes four seconds.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Show rate. Booked calls that actually happened. If this sags, the problem is in the gap between booking and the call, not in the call itself — reminders, timing, how far out you're letting people schedule.

Close rate. Of calls that happened, how many bought.

Track both, always. Close rate alone rewards cherry-picking — a rep who only takes easy calls looks excellent and produces less. The number that matters is calls booked to deals closed, end to end.

What "good" looks like: improving against your own last twenty. And per Chapter 5, a close rate above half usually means your price is low, not that your calls are great.

DO THIS NOW

35 minutes

Write your opening frame — the 30-second version above, in your own words. Say it out loud until it doesn't sound read.

Then pick fifteen questions from the bank and put them in a document in the order you'll ask them. Not all of them. Fifteen you'll actually use.

Print it. Keep it next to you on every call for the next month. Reading questions off a page is completely fine and nobody can tell. Forgetting to ask what they've tried before is not fine, and you will forget, because you'll be nervous.

10

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 4 — CLOSE

The Twelve Objections

By the end of this chapter you'll recognize every objection a local owner is likely to raise, know what each one actually means, and have your own answer written for all twelve.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The objection that used to beat you. The one you'd hear and know the call was over. What it was, how many times it happened, and what you eventually figured out to say.

AUTHOR NOTE — RESPONSES NEED ISAIAH'S ACTUAL WORDS

The twelve below are the objections local service owners raise; that part is market reality and stands. What each objection *means* and the shape of a good answer is teaching, and it stands. But the specific wording should be replaced with what Isaiah actually says on calls. Structures teach; his words sell.

An objection is not resistance. It's information, arriving late.

Every objection you hear on a call is a question the prospect had at minute four and didn't ask. By the time it comes out of his mouth as "let me think about it," it's been sitting there getting heavier for twenty minutes.

Which means the best objection handling happens before the objection. Most of this chapter is about hearing them early.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Every objection is one of three things: they don't believe it'll work, they don't believe it'll work for them, or the timing is genuinely wrong. Find out which before you answer.

Why most people get this wrong

They treat objections as things to overcome, so they argue. And the moment you argue, you've turned a conversation into a contest, and the prospect's job becomes defending his position instead of considering yours.

There's also a habit of answering the words instead of the meaning. "It's too expensive" gets a discount. But "too expensive" almost never means "I don't have the money" — it usually means "I don't yet believe this returns more than it costs," which a discount doesn't fix. It makes it worse, because you've just proved the number was made up.

Answer what they meant, not what they said. Discounting a belief problem just tells them your price was never real.

The system

THREE MOVES, IN ORDER

- 1. Acknowledge it as reasonable.** Not "I understand, but." Just agree that it's a fair thing to be thinking.
- 2. Ask one question to find out which of the three it is.** This is the move nobody makes. You cannot answer an objection you haven't diagnosed, and the same eight words can mean three different things.
- 3. Answer the actual version.** Short. Then return to the decision.

THE TWELVE

WHAT THEY SAY	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS	THE SHAPE OF THE ANSWER
1. "It's too expensive."	Not a budget problem — a return problem. He can't yet see the arithmetic	Go back to his own numbers. Job value $\times$ close rate = what one appointment is worth. Let the arithmetic answer it, not you
2. "I already have a guy."	Often true and often barely active. Sometimes a polite exit	Ask what the guy does and what results look like. If he can't answer, that's the answer. Don't attack the incumbent — ask questions until the gap shows itself
3. "I tried an agency before and it didn't work."	Real damage. This is the most common objection in local service and the most winnable	Ask exactly what happened. Then name the specific difference in what you do — mechanism, not enthusiasm. Never say the last agency was bad
4. "I'm too busy right now."	Either genuinely slammed, or a soft no	Ask when the season turns. If they're truly booked, the honest move is to schedule for six weeks before their next slow stretch — and say so. Booking the right month beats forcing the wrong one
5. "I get all my work from referrals."	Usually true, and usually flat. Referrals don't scale on purpose	Ask what happens in a slow month. Referral flow is a number he doesn't control, and most owners have felt that
6. "Let me think about it."	Almost always an unspoken objection you never surfaced	Ask what specifically he wants to think through. The real objection is behind this sentence and it comes out when you ask directly
7. "Let me talk to my wife / partner."	Sometimes real, sometimes cover	You should have found this at minute fifteen with "who else is in on the decision." If it appears now, get the next call booked with both of them on it — never leave it as a promise to circle back
8. "How do I know you can do this?"	Belief problem. Fair, especially early	Specificity beats credentials. Walk him through the mechanism in detail — where leads come from, what the follow-up does, what happens at 8pm. A person who can describe it precisely is more believable than one with a vague promise
9. "Can you guarantee results?"	He wants risk removed	Never guarantee income. Commit to a defined service level you control. If you offer any assurance, define it in appointments delivered, never dollars earned — see Chapter 6 on why this matters in Massachusetts

WHAT THEY SAY	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS	THE SHAPE OF THE ANSWER
10. "Just send me some information."	Polite exit, nine times out of ten	Agree to send it, and book the time to discuss it before you hang up. Information sent without a next date is information nobody reads
11. "I don't need more customers."	Occasionally true. More often means "I don't need more of the customers I currently get"	Ask about the jobs he actually wants — bigger tickets, better areas, less price-shopping. Volume isn't the only thing you can change
12. "You're young."	Rarely said out loud. Often thought	Don't apologize for it and don't oversell around it. Answer with the mechanism and with your presence — you're local, you're reachable, and you'll be standing in his parking lot when the overseas agency won't

ON NUMBER THREE

Objection three deserves special attention because it's the one your buyer profile is built around. A large share of local owners have already paid someone and gotten nothing.

The instinct is to distance yourself: "yeah, a lot of agencies are bad." Don't. It sounds like every other salesperson and it teaches him nothing.

Ask instead. What did they do? How long? What did the reporting look like? Did anyone ever tell you what was actually happening?

Two things come out of that. You learn the specific failure, which lets you address the specific thing. And he gets to say it out loud to someone who's listening, which is worth more than any rebuttal you had ready.

ON NUMBER TWELVE

You will be the youngest person in most rooms you sell in. Some of the people you're pitching have been running their business longer than you've been alive.

The two failure modes are apologizing for it and overcompensating with jargon. Both read as insecurity.

What works is being the most specific person in the conversation. Age reads as inexperience only in the absence of precision. Someone who can describe exactly what will happen in week one, week two, and week three doesn't sound young. He sounds like he's done it.

The asset

OBJECTION WORKSHEET — FILL THIS IN FOR ALL TWELVE

OBJECTION: _____

WHICH IS IT? ☐ Doesn't believe it works

☐ Doesn't believe it works for HIM

☐ Timing is genuinely wrong

MY DIAGNOSTIC QUESTION:

MY ANSWER (three sentences max, in my own words):

RETURN TO THE DECISION:

Full version with all twelve laid out: **Objection Handling One-Pager** in the asset vault.

Failure modes

You answer before you diagnose.

FIX — Ask one question first, every time. "Too expensive" has three different meanings and only one of them is about money.

You discount to beat a price objection.

FIX — Adjust scope instead — drop a channel or a reporting cadence. Cutting price with scope unchanged teaches him your number was invented.

You attack the previous agency.

FIX — Ask what happened and listen. Criticizing the last guy makes you sound like the last guy, who also criticized someone.

You accept "let me think about it" at face value.

FIX — Ask what specifically he wants to think through. Nine times in ten there's a real objection sitting underneath, and it's answerable.

You promise results to end the discomfort.

FIX — Have your service-level language written down before the call so you never improvise it. This is the objection most likely to make you say something you can't stand behind.

You treat every objection as winnable.

FIX — Some are real. A genuinely slammed contractor in peak season is not a close, he's a follow-up in eight weeks. Book that and move on — pushing costs you the future deal.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Objection frequency. After every call, write down which objections came up. After twenty calls you'll have a ranked list, and it will not be the list you expected.

That ranking is worth more than this chapter. Whatever sits at the top is something to fix upstream — in your outreach, your qualifying, or your framing — rather than something to keep handling on calls.

Close rate after objection. Of calls where a given objection appeared, how many closed anyway? This tells you which of your answers are working and which just feel like they are.

What "good" looks like: the same objection appearing less often over time, because you started answering it before it was asked.

DO THIS NOW

45 minutes

Take the twelve above. For each one, write your own answer in three sentences or fewer, in the words you'd actually use — not the words in this book.

Then do the part that matters: **say each one out loud.** Any answer you can't say smoothly is one you won't say under pressure. Rewrite those until they come out clean.

Keep the sheet next to you on calls. Add a tally mark every time an objection comes up. In a month, that tally tells you exactly what to fix.

THE TWELVE OBJECTIONS

PART FOUR

The Delivery Machine

Getting the client is half of it. This is the half that decides whether you still have them in ninety days.

STAGES COVERED · **BUILD** · **PROOF**

THE TWELVE OBJECTIONS

11

THE DOMINO SYSTEM • STAGE 5 — BUILD

Register Before You Build

By the end of this chapter you'll have messaging registration started on day one instead of discovering it in week three — and you'll know why that single sequencing decision protects the client relationship.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

Your own A2P 10DLC registration. What got rejected and why. How long it actually took versus what you expected. What you'd tell someone doing it Monday morning.

This is the least exciting chapter in the book and probably the most valuable one.

Nobody makes content about carrier registration. There's no thumbnail in it. But it is the single most common reason a new agency's first client spends three weeks paying for silence — and a client who pays for three weeks of silence is a client who leaves in month two.

ACCURATE AS OF AUGUST 2026

Carrier requirements, fees, and processing times in this chapter change. Everything below reflects the rules and pricing in effect as of **August 2026**. Verify current requirements with your provider before you rely on any specific number here. The sequencing advice — register first — does not change.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Registration runs on carrier time, not your time. It is the only part of the build you cannot compress, so it starts on day one — before the pipeline, before the automations, before anything.

Why most people get this wrong

They build in the order that feels natural, which is the order of visible progress.

Set up the account. Build the pipeline. Write the automations. Design the follow-up sequence. Test it — and discover the texts aren't going anywhere. Then start registration, which takes another week or two, during which the client is watching nothing happen and wondering what he's paying for.

The failure isn't technical. Everyone gets registered eventually. **The failure is sequencing**, and it costs you the most valuable asset you have with a new client: the first thirty days, when their patience is at its maximum and their doubt is at its minimum.

Your client's goodwill is highest on day one and it depletes daily. Spending the first three weeks of it on a form you could have filed on day one is the most avoidable mistake in this business.

What A2P 10DLC actually is

Application-to-Person messaging over 10-digit long codes. In plain terms: when software sends a text from a normal-looking phone number, that's A2P. It's what your CRM does.

US carriers — AT&T, T-Mobile, Verizon — built a registration system to cut down spam. You register who you are and what you're going to send, and they decide whether your traffic gets through.

The part people miss: **since February 2025, unregistered A2P traffic is blocked outright.** Not slowed. Not delivered to spam. Blocked. Your messages leave your system, report as sent, and never arrive. You can look at a dashboard full of sent messages while the client's leads hear nothing.

Two things register, and they're separate:

The brand is the business. Legal name, EIN, address, contact. One per business.

The campaign is the use case. What kind of messages, sample copy, and how people opted in. One brand can have several campaigns.

The system

1. COLLECT WHAT YOU NEED BEFORE YOU OPEN THE FORM

Half of rejections come from mismatched details. The legal name and EIN have to match IRS records exactly — not the trade name, not the name on the truck.

- ☐ Legal business name, exactly as registered with the IRS
- ☐ EIN, and the address on the EIN filing
- ☐ Business type and industry
- ☐ Website URL, live, with a visible privacy policy
- ☐ Contact name, email on the business domain, and phone
- ☐ Sample messages — the actual text you'll send
- ☐ A description of how people opt in, plus a screenshot of the form

2. FIX THE WEBSITE FIRST

The most common rejection cause is a website that doesn't back up the application.

The reviewer is checking that you are what you say you are. So the site needs to be live, to describe the business the campaign describes, and — this is the one people miss — to have a **privacy policy that specifically mentions SMS**, stating that mobile information isn't sold or shared with third parties for marketing.

If your client's opt-in is a web form, that form needs visible consent language next to the submit button. Not buried in terms. Next to the button.

3. REGISTER THE BRAND, THEN THE CAMPAIGN

Brand first. It's usually approved in **one to three business days**.

Then the campaign, which is the slower and pickier half: **three to seven business days**, and **ten to fifteen during busy periods**.

Campaign rejections almost always trace to one of three things: sample messages that don't match the stated use case, opt-in language that doesn't show real consent, or a use case description too vague to evaluate.

Write sample messages that are actually representative. If you'll send appointment reminders, the sample should be an appointment reminder with the placeholders filled in — not a generic greeting.

4. BUDGET FOR IT

Approximate costs as of August 2026:

ITEM	COST	FREQUENCY
Brand registration — sole proprietor	~\$4	One-time
Brand registration — standard, with vetting	~\$48+	One-time
Campaign vetting	~\$15-17	Per campaign
Campaign monthly fee	~\$1.50-\$10	Monthly, varies by use case
Carrier surcharges	~\$0.003-\$0.005	Per message segment

Small money. Put it in your setup fee so it isn't a line item conversation later.

5. SAY IT OUT LOUD ON THE SALES CALL

This is the move that turns a liability into an advantage.

On the discovery call, when you describe the build, tell them: "First thing I do is get your messaging registered with the carriers. That takes about a week and it's out of my hands — but if we don't do it first, none of your texts get delivered. Most people find that out three weeks in."

Two things happen. You've set the expectation before it can become a complaint. And you've demonstrated that you know something the last agency didn't — which does more for your credibility than any case study, especially given how many of your prospects have been burned before.

The asset

A2P 10DLC REGISTRATION CHECKLIST — DAY ONE

BEFORE THE FORM

- ☐ Legal name matches IRS records exactly
- ☐ EIN + registered address confirmed
- ☐ Website live and describes this business
- ☐ Privacy policy mentions SMS specifically
- ☐ Privacy policy says mobile data is not sold or shared with third parties for marketing
- ☐ Opt-in consent visible next to the form's submit button
- ☐ Screenshot of the opt-in saved

BRAND (1-3 business days)

- ☐ Submitted date: _____
- ☐ Approved date: _____

CAMPAIGN (3-7 business days, up to 15 when busy)

- ☐ Use case selected
- ☐ Sample messages written - representative, not generic
- ☐ Opt-in flow described in plain language
- ☐ Submitted date: _____
- ☐ Approved date: _____

AFTER APPROVAL

- ☐ Send a real test to your own phone
- ☐ Confirm STOP works and is honored
- ☐ Confirm HELP returns business name and contact
- ☐ Log approval dates where the client can see them

Full version: **A2P 10DLC Registration Checklist** in the asset vault.

REGISTRATION IS NOT CONSENT

Getting approved by the carriers does not give you permission to message anyone. Those are two separate things and people conflate them constantly.

Registration is the carriers agreeing to deliver your traffic. **Consent** is the recipient agreeing to receive it, and that's governed by the TCPA — which has moved twice recently and has another change scheduled. Chapter 17 covers the current state in detail.

Short version: you still need proper consent for every number you message, you still have to honor opt-outs promptly, and if a client hands you a list, find out how it was collected before you send anything. Their list becomes your problem the moment you press send.

Failure modes

You build everything else first.

FIX — Submit registration on day one, before you touch the pipeline. It runs in the background while you do the work you control.

Legal name doesn't match the EIN.

FIX — Ask for the EIN letter or a tax filing rather than the name on the truck. This single mismatch causes more rejections than everything else combined.

The privacy policy doesn't mention SMS.

FIX — Add the language before submitting. A site with no SMS clause is a predictable rejection and costs you a full week.

Sample messages don't match the use case.

FIX — Write the actual messages you'll send with placeholders filled in. Generic samples read as evasive and get bounced.

You promise a go-live date before approval lands.

FIX — Quote the range including the slow case, and tell the client the clock is the carriers', not yours. Under-promise here; you don't control this timeline.

You never test after approval.

FIX — Send a real message to your own phone. Check STOP and HELP work. Approved is not the same as working.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Days from signature to campaign approval. Log it for every client. It's the first hard number in your delivery process and the one you can most reliably improve.

Rejection rate and reason. Track why. After three or four clients, the same reason will repeat, and it'll be something in your intake you can fix permanently.

What "good" looks like: submitted within one business day of signature, every time. Approval itself isn't yours to control — submission speed entirely is, and that's the number to hold yourself to.

DO THIS NOW

40 minutes

Register your own business first, before you ever do it for a client. You need to have felt the process.

If you have an EIN, start the brand registration today in whatever platform you're using. If you don't have one, apply — it's free and takes about ten minutes on the IRS site.

While that's processing, write your intake list: every piece of information you'll need to collect from a client on day one to submit theirs without a follow-up email. Put it in your onboarding form.

That list is worth more than the registration. It's what turns a three-week delay into a one-day submission for every client after this.

REGISTER BEFORE YOU BUILD

12

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 5 — BUILD

The Build

By the end of this chapter you'll stand up a working client account in a defined order, and know which pieces must exist before you turn anything on.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The first build you did for a paying client. What broke. What you didn't know you needed until it was missing. How long it actually took versus what you told them.

AUTHOR NOTE — NEEDS ISAIAH'S ACTUAL BUILD

This chapter gives the build order and the architecture, which transfer across any CRM. What it cannot supply is Isaiah's specific implementation: his real pipeline stage names, which automations fire on which triggers, how his Conversation AI is prompted and where it hands off to a human, and what's inside his snapshot. Those details are what make this chapter un-copyable. Replace the bracketed sections before publication.

ON SOFTWARE INTERFACES

This book describes GoHighLevel because that's the platform this agency runs on, and the architecture below applies to any CRM with pipelines, automations, and a calendar. **Interfaces change constantly.** Menu names and click paths in any book about software are wrong within a year. What doesn't change is the order you build in and the reason for each piece — that's what this chapter is really about. Screenshots and exact paths, where included, are accurate as of the date noted.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Build in the order of dependency, not the order of visibility. The pieces that block other pieces go first, even when they show the client nothing.

Why most people get this wrong

They build the fun parts first.

Automations are satisfying. Dragging a workflow together and watching it fire feels like real progress. So that's where the first day goes — and then the whole thing sits idle for a week because messaging isn't registered, or because nobody defined what happens when a lead comes in at 8pm on a Saturday.

The other mistake is building something too complicated to hand over. If your client can't understand where a lead is in the process by glancing at one screen, you've built a system that requires you to interpret it — which means every question becomes a phone call, and your margin quietly disappears into support.

A build the client can read is worth more than a build that's clever. You're not being paid for complexity. You're being paid for a full calendar.

The system

BUILD ORDER

#	STEP	WHY HERE
1	A2P 10DLC brand + campaign submitted	Runs on carrier time. Blocks all SMS. Day one, no exceptions
2	Sub-account, phone number, domain, email sending	Everything else attaches to these
3	Calendar — availability, duration, buffers	The appointment is the product. It gets defined before anything that books into it
4	Pipeline stages	Automations move contacts between stages, so the stages must exist first
5	Intake — forms, landing page, tracking number	The front door. Consent language lives here
6	Speed-to-lead automation	The single highest-impact automation. Built before the nurture sequences
7	Appointment reminders	Protects the show rate, which is what you're actually selling
8	Long-term nurture	Matters most later; least urgent on day one
9	Reporting view	The one screen the client looks at. Chapter 14
10	Test the whole path as a fake lead	Never skip. Never

THE CLIENT-SIDE PIPELINE

This is the client's pipeline for their customers — different from your outreach pipeline in Chapter 7.

NEW	lead just arrived, not yet contacted
CONTACTED	first touch out, no response yet
ENGAGED	they replied
APPOINTMENT SET	time on the calendar
SHOWED	they turned up
WON	client closed the job
LOST	disqualified, or gone cold after full follow-up

REPLACE WITH ISAIAH'S ACTUAL STAGE NAMES

The stages above are a sound generic architecture. Isaiah's real stage names, and any stage he added that isn't here, should replace them — including anything vertical-specific.

Two things about this pipeline matter more than the names.

SHOWED is its own stage. Not folded into WON. The gap between APPOINTMENT SET and SHOWED is your show rate, and show rate is the number you're actually being paid to move. If you can't see it, you can't defend your invoice.

LOST needs a reason field. Six weeks in, the pattern in the lost reasons tells you more about what to fix than any other data in the account.

SPEED TO LEAD IS THE WHOLE GAME

If you build one automation properly, build this one.

The research here is solid and it's old enough to have been re-confirmed many times. A Harvard Business Review study of 2,241 US companies — Oldroyd, McElheran and Elkington, published in 2011 — found that firms attempting contact within an hour of an inquiry were about **seven times** more likely to qualify the lead than those trying an hour later, and more than **sixty times** more likely than those who waited a day.

That study is from 2011, which means it describes a world with less competition for attention than yours. The direction of the finding has not softened since.

So the first automation fires **immediately**. Not in five minutes. On submission.

SPEED-TO-LEAD — THE SHAPE

TRIGGER form submitted / call missed / message received

0 min SMS to lead, from the business, personalized
with what they asked about
0 min Notify the owner - push and SMS
2 min Email to lead with the booking link
5 min If no reply: automated call attempt to the lead
15 min If still nothing: task assigned to a human
1 hr Second SMS, different angle
1 day Follow-up
3 day Final touch, then move to long-term nurture

STOP RULE any reply from the lead halts the sequence
immediately and hands to a human

That stop rule is not optional. A lead who replies and keeps receiving automated messages knows exactly what happened, and it costs you the goodwill the speed just bought.

REPLACE WITH ISAIAH'S ACTUAL TRIGGERS AND TIMINGS

The cadence above is a reasonable architecture. His real intervals, channels, and branch conditions should replace it.

CONVERSATION AI, AND WHERE IT STOPS

Automated conversation handling is genuinely useful for the first exchange — answering at 11pm, qualifying, offering times. It is not useful for closing, for anything emotional, or for anything where being wrong is expensive.

Three rules worth building in:

Hand off on any signal of confusion, frustration, or complexity. If the lead asks something the AI can't answer confidently, it goes to a person. Build the escalation trigger before you build the conversation.

Never let it invent specifics. Prices, availability, guarantees, and timelines come from real data or they don't get said. An AI that improvises a price has created a problem your client will hear about.

Disclose appropriately. Rules on AI disclosure in customer messaging are tightening. Beyond the legal question, a customer who discovers they were misled about talking to a person is a review problem for your client.

NEEDS ISAIAH'S ACTUAL CONVERSATION AI SETUP

His prompt structure, his qualifying questions, his handoff triggers, and what he learned about where it breaks. This is one of the most valuable sections in the book and it can only come from him.

SNAPSHOT IT

Once you've built one account you're happy with, save it as a reusable template.

Every client after that starts from the snapshot and gets customized, rather than being built from nothing. That's the difference between a four-day build and a four-hour one — and it's the operational version of the same domino principle the whole book runs on. The first one costs everything; the tenth costs almost nothing.

NEEDS THE CONTENTS OF ISAIAH'S SNAPSHOT

What's actually in it, what he leaves out on purpose, and what he learned to customize per client rather than templating.

Failure modes

You build automations before registration is submitted.

FIX — Submit on day one and build while it processes. Reordering these two costs a week of the client's patience.

The speed-to-lead automation has a delay in it.

FIX — Fire on submission. Any delay you add is measurable money, and the first five minutes are worth more than the next five hours.

Automated messages keep sending after a lead replies.

FIX — Build the stop rule into every sequence and test it by replying to your own test lead. Assume it's broken until you've seen it stop.

There's no SHOWED stage.

FIX — Add it. Without it you cannot report on show rate, which is the number that justifies your fee.

You go live without testing as a real lead.

FIX — Submit the form from your own phone, on cellular, not on your desk. Follow it the whole way through and watch every message arrive.

The build is too complex for the client to read.

FIX — If explaining where a lead sits takes more than one sentence, simplify. You'll pay for the complexity in support calls forever.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Time from signature to first live lead. The build's real output. Everything in this chapter exists to shorten it.

Median speed to first contact. Measured in seconds, not minutes. If it's creeping up, something in the automation is failing quietly.

What "good" looks like: first contact effectively instant, and a build you can reproduce from a snapshot in hours rather than days. The absolute time-to-live depends on how fast registration clears, which isn't yours to control — the part you own is that nothing else is waiting on you.

DO THIS NOW

45 minutes

Build the client-side pipeline in your own sub-account, using the seven stages above. Add a reason field on LOST.

Then build one automation, and only one: **speed to lead.** Trigger on form submission, immediate SMS to the lead, immediate notification to the owner, and the stop rule on reply.

Then test it as a real lead. Take out your phone, off wifi, and fill in the form like a stranger would. Watch what arrives and when.

Whatever you find broken in that test is the thing that would have broken in front of your first client.

THE BUILD

13

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 5 → 6

The First Booked Appointment

By the end of this chapter you'll know which single moment predicts whether a client stays — and you'll have built your entire onboarding to reach it faster.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

Two clients: one whose first appointment landed fast, one where it dragged. What was different, and how the two relationships went from there. This is the chapter where a contrast does more work than a single story.

There's a moment in every client relationship where the thing stops being a promise and becomes a fact.

It isn't the kickoff call. It isn't the day the dashboard goes live. It isn't the first lead in the system.

It's the first time a real human being sits in their calendar because of work you did.

Everything before that moment is you asking for patience. Everything after it is a conversation between two people who have evidence.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Your client's first booked appointment is the activation point. Getting there fast does more for retention than anything else in delivery, and everything in onboarding should be bent toward it.

Why most people get this wrong

They treat onboarding as administration. Collect logins, set up accounts, send a welcome packet, book a monthly check-in. All the boxes get ticked and nothing is aimed at anything.

The concept that fixes this is the **activation point**, which comes from Alex Hormozi's retention work. The idea is that in any business there's a specific thing customers do — or get — that separates the ones who stay from the ones who leave. Find it, then engineer every new customer toward it deliberately instead of hoping.

For a lead-generation agency serving local service businesses, that thing is almost certainly the first booked appointment. Not the first lead. A lead is still a promise — it's a name on a screen that might be nothing. An appointment is a person with a time.

A lead is a promise. An appointment is a fact. Your client can't tell the difference between a promise and a lie until one of them turns into a fact.

CONFIRM AGAINST REAL RETENTION HISTORY

Before publication, check this against the clients who stayed versus the ones who left. If the real dividing line was something else — first closed job, first month of positive return, something else entirely — say that instead. The method holds either way; the specific activation point should be the true one.

WHY THE CLOCK MATTERS SO MUCH

Two things are running down at the same time in month one.

The client's patience, which is at its highest on day one and drops a little every day nothing visible happens.

And the client's memory of why he signed, which is vivid the week he signs and fades fast.

You cannot slow either one. All you can do is get the evidence in front of him before they run out.

The system

WORK BACKWARDS FROM THE APPOINTMENT

List everything that has to be true for one appointment to exist. Then ask what's blocking each item and attack the longest pole first.

WHAT MUST BE TRUE	WHAT BLOCKS IT	WHERE IT'S HANDLED
Messages can be delivered	Carrier registration, 3-15 days	Chapter 11 — day one
Leads can arrive	Intake, tracking, traffic source	Chapter 12
Leads get contacted instantly	Speed-to-lead automation	Chapter 12
There are times to book into	Client's calendar availability	This chapter
Someone confirms the time	Reminder sequence	This chapter

Registration is the longest pole and it's the one you can start earliest. That's the whole argument of Chapter 11 restated as a delivery problem.

THE FOUR LEVERS ON GETTING PEOPLE TO SHOW

Alex Hormozi's lead nurture work identifies four drivers of whether a lead schedules and shows: **availability, speed, personalization, and volume**. All four translate directly to a local service client's calendar.

Availability. How many slots exist, and how soon. This is the one that surprises people — more bookable time produces more booked appointments, and it usually matters more than response speed does. It's also the lever your client controls and resists.

Most contractors will tell you they can do estimates "whenever." That's not availability, that's ambiguity, and nothing can book into it. Get real windows on a real calendar. Then push for more of them, including at least some outside working hours, because the homeowner deciding to get a quote is doing it at 8pm.

Speed. Covered in Chapter 12. Instant, or you're paying for leads someone else talks to first.

Personalization. A confirmation that references what they actually asked about beats a generic one. The system already captured it on the form — use it.

Volume of follow-up. Most people give up after one attempt. The appointment you wanted was often on touch four. Build the sequence so persistence is automatic rather than a decision someone makes when they're tired.

THE REMINDER STACK

Booking is half the job. Showing up is the other half, and an appointment that no-shows is worse than no appointment — your client blocked time, drove somewhere, and got nothing.

REMINDER SEQUENCE

ON BOOKING	immediate confirmation - date, time, who is coming, and the number it will come from
24 HRS OUT	reminder, automated, clearly automated
3 HRS OUT	reminder with a one-tap way to reschedule rather than cancel
DAY OF	short message from a real number, written like a person
RESCHEDULE	any cancel or reschedule request goes straight to a human, never to a form

Two details that matter more than they look.

Say the number you'll be calling from. Pickup rates on unknown numbers are terrible, and this one line fixes a chunk of it.

Let people reschedule easily. Making it hard to reschedule doesn't produce shows, it produces no-shows. A rescheduled appointment is a live opportunity; a no-show is a dead one.

DAY 0 TO 14

DAY 0 Signature. A2P registration submitted same day.
Onboarding call booked before the call ends.

DAY 1 Onboarding call. Collect access. Set calendar availability - real windows, in writing. Resell the outcome in his words. Tell him exactly what happens in the next 14 days, including the registration wait and why it exists.

DAY 2-4 Build while registration processes. Send one short progress note even though nothing is live. Silence in week one is what kills month two.

DAY 5 Test the whole path as a fake lead. Show the client the test. Seeing it work before it is live buys you the remaining wait.

DAY 7+ Registration clears. Go live. Tell him the hour it happened.

FIRST Call him the day it happens. Do not email. Do
APPT not wait for the weekly report. Call him.

DAY 14 First real review: what came in, what booked, what to change.

That progress note on day two through four is the cheapest retention work in this book. Nothing is live, there's nothing to report, and you send a note anyway — because the client's experience of "nothing is happening" and your experience of "I'm building" are the same week seen from opposite sides.

CALL HIM WHEN IT LANDS

When the first appointment books, pick up the phone.

Not an email. Not a line in the weekly report. A phone call, the day it happens, saying: "You've got a real one on the calendar Thursday at two. Here's what they asked about."

That call is the moment the relationship changes, and doing it live rather than in writing is worth more than the effort difference suggests. It's also the natural moment to set up the referral conversation you'll have later, in Chapter 16.

Failure modes

The client's calendar has almost no availability.

FIX — Push for real windows in writing during onboarding, including evenings. Vague availability books nothing, and this is the lever with the biggest effect that you don't directly control.

You go quiet during the registration wait.

FIX — Send a short progress note every two or three days. From his side, building and doing nothing look identical.

Reminders come from a number nobody recognizes.

FIX — State the calling number in the confirmation and every reminder. One line, meaningful effect on pickup.

Rescheduling is hard.

FIX — Make it one tap and route it to a person. Friction here converts live opportunities into dead ones.

The first appointment happens and you don't mention it.

FIX — Call the day it lands. This is the single highest-value phone call in the entire relationship and it takes ninety seconds.

You measure leads instead of appointments.

FIX — Report booked and shown appointments. Leads are a number your client has learned not to trust, usually because someone else taught him that.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Days from signature to first booked appointment. The activation metric. Track it for every client, and treat a rise in it as a fire.

Show rate. Booked appointments that turned up. This is the number that most directly justifies your invoice, and it's where the four levers above show their effect.

What "good" looks like: as fast as registration allows, with nothing else waiting on you. Set your internal standard so that every step you control is done before the carrier clock runs out.

DO THIS NOW

30 minutes

Write your day 0 to 14 onboarding sequence as a checklist, in the order above, adjusted for how you actually work.

Then add the two items most people don't have: **a progress note on day three even though nothing is live**, and **a phone call on the day the first appointment books**.

Put both in the checklist as required steps, not as nice-to-haves. They're the two cheapest things in your delivery process and they do more for retention than anything else you'll build this month.

THE FIRST BOOKED APPOINTMENT

14

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 6 — PROOF

Reporting That Keeps You Hired

By the end of this chapter you'll report in your client's language, on a rhythm that protects you, and you'll know what to say in a month that went badly.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

A client who didn't believe the results were real. What he said, what you showed him, and how it resolved. Or the report you sent that made everything worse.

Most agency reporting is written to look impressive rather than to be understood, and you can tell because of what's in it.

Impressions. Reach. Click-through rate. Cost per click. Engagement rate. Twelve charts.

Here's what the guy receiving it is thinking: I don't know what any of this means, I don't know if it's good, and I'm paying \$1,500 a month.

He won't say that. He'll say "great, thanks." And then in month four he'll cancel, and you'll be surprised, because the reports were so thorough.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Report the numbers your client already thinks in. For a local service business that's appointments booked, appointments shown, and jobs won. Everything else is your diagnostic, not his report.

Why most people get this wrong

Two reasons, and the second is the uncomfortable one.

They report what the platform gives them. The ad dashboard produces impressions and CTR, so that's what goes in the report. But those are your inputs, not his outputs. He never asked for impressions. He asked for a full calendar.

They report volume when results are thin. This is the honest reason. When a month is bad, twelve charts of activity are a way of demonstrating effort without stating the outcome. Every client eventually learns to read a fat report as a hiding place.

A one-page report that leads with a bad number builds more trust than a twelve-page report that buries it. He already knows the month was slow. He's watching to see whether you'll say so.

The lookback window

This is the mechanic that explains most agency churn, and once you see it you can't unsee it.

Clients do not judge you across the relationship. They judge you across the last billing cycle.

You deliver an outstanding January. February is decent. March is slow. In April, the conversation is entirely about March — and if you say "but look at January," he hears an excuse. In his head, January was already paid for by January's invoice.

The framing comes from Alex Hormozi's pricing work, and it has three practical consequences.

Report every cycle, without exception. A month with no report is a month where the window is empty and he fills it with whatever he's feeling.

Bill on the longest cycle he'll accept. A longer billing period is a longer window to be judged over, which smooths out the variance that's inherent in this work.

Front-load the value. A result in week one of a cycle sits in the window the whole time. A result in the last week barely registers before the invoice lands.

The system

ONE PAGE, FOUR NUMBERS, IN THIS ORDER

THIS MONTH	Aug 1 - Aug 31
Appointments booked	_____
Appointments shown	_____ (____% show rate)
Jobs won (you told us)	_____
Estimated revenue from those	\$_____
Cost of the program	\$_____
Cost per booked appointment	\$_____
Cost per shown appointment	\$_____
WHAT CHANGED THIS MONTH	

WHAT I AM CHANGING NEXT MONTH	

WHAT I NEED FROM YOU	

Four numbers, then three sentences. That's the whole report and it fits on a phone screen.

The last three lines do more than the numbers. They tell him you're paying attention, that you have a plan, and — critically — that some of the outcome depends on him.

"JOBS WON (YOU TOLD US)"

That parenthetical matters more than it looks.

You cannot verify what your client closed. You know what you delivered; you don't know what happened at the kitchen table. So label it as reported rather than measured.

Two things come of that. You're accurate, which protects you if anyone ever scrutinizes your claims. And you've created a monthly reason for him to tell you what closed — which is the number you need for your own case studies later, and the one most agencies never collect.

KEEP YOUR DIAGNOSTICS SEPARATE

You still need the platform numbers. Cost per click, creative performance, which source produces which appointments — that's how you improve.

Keep it in your own view, not his. If he asks, show him. If he doesn't, don't put it in front of him, because every number you add dilutes the four that matter.

THE WEEKLY RHYTHM

Monthly reports alone leave too much silence.

Weekly: a two-line message. Appointments booked this week, anything that needs him. Thirty seconds to write, and it keeps the lookback window continuously full.

Monthly: the one-pager above.

Quarterly: a real conversation about what's working, what he wants more of, and whether the scope still fits. Chapter 15 covers what that call is actually for.

THE BAD MONTH

You will have them. The messaging goes stale, the season turns, a competitor starts spending, or it's just variance.

Send the report anyway, on time, with the bad number at the top.

THE BAD MONTH MESSAGE

"August was down - 6 booked against 11 in July.

Here's what I think happened: [specific diagnosis, not 'the algorithm changed'].

Here's what I'm changing: [one or two specific things, with dates].

Here's what I need from you: [something concrete, or 'nothing, this one's on me'].

I'll have the first read on whether it's working by [date]."

Three rules. Say the number first. Never blame the platform in the abstract — "the algorithm changed" is what people say when they haven't looked. And commit to a

date when you'll know something, because the worst part of a bad month for a client isn't the bad month, it's not knowing whether anyone's on it.

ON RESULTS CLAIMS

The FTC's Endorsement Guides, revised effective July 2023, require that testimonial and endorsement claims be truthful and represent typical results, with material connections disclosed clearly and conspicuously — where "clear and conspicuous" means genuinely hard to miss, not buried in fine print.

This applies twice over. It governs how you use a client's results in your own marketing, and it governs the ad copy you write on their behalf. If you build an ad claiming an outcome that isn't typical for their customers, you've created their exposure, and in Massachusetts a deceptive claim also runs into c. 93A. Ask for written permission before using any client's numbers, and label what's typical. Chapter 17 has the detail.

Failure modes

Your report leads with impressions.

FIX — Delete every platform metric from the client-facing page. Keep them in your own view where they belong.

You skip the report in a bad month.

FIX — Send it on time with the bad number first. A missing report is read as hiding, and it's the moment a client starts looking around.

You report leads instead of appointments.

FIX — Report booked and shown. "Lead" is a word most local owners have already learned to distrust.

You never ask what closed.

FIX — Ask every month and label it as reported. It's the number that makes your case studies real, and nobody will volunteer it.

The report takes you two hours to produce.

FIX — Build the view once so the numbers are already there. A report that's expensive to make is a report you'll start skipping.

You use a client's results publicly without asking.

FIX — Get written permission naming exactly what you may share. Do it while they're happy, in writing, and keep it.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Cost per shown appointment. The cleanest measure of whether the program works. It combines everything upstream into one number both of you can act on.

Reporting consistency. Percentage of months where the report went out on time. Target is 100%, and the months you miss will be exactly the bad ones — which is precisely when it matters.

Client-reported jobs won. Chase it monthly. It's the bridge between what you delivered and what he actually cares about, and it's the raw material for every case study you'll ever write.

What "good" looks like: a cost per shown appointment that's a clear fraction of what one job is worth to him, and a client who can state that ratio from memory. When he can say it himself, you're not being evaluated any more.

DO THIS NOW

35 minutes

Build the one-page report as a template — the four numbers and the three sentences, nothing else.

Then go into your platform and build the view that produces those four numbers without you assembling anything by hand. If it takes more than five minutes a month to fill in, simplify until it doesn't.

If you have a client already, send this month's version today, even mid-month, even if the numbers are ordinary. Getting the rhythm started matters more than the timing of the first one.

PART FIVE

Keeping It

Churn is a delivery problem wearing a marketing costume. This part is about the work that makes the tenth client cost less than the first.

STAGES COVERED · **PROOF** · **TIP**

REPORTING THAT KEEPS YOU HIRED

15

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 6 — PROOF

How Not to Get Fired in Month Two

By the end of this chapter you'll spot a client leaving weeks before they say anything, and you'll know why adding more deliverables usually makes it worse.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The client you lost. What the last month looked like, what they said when they cancelled, and what actually broke — which is usually not what they said.

Nobody cancels on the day they decide to cancel.

They decide weeks earlier, usually in a quiet moment, and then they wait until the next invoice makes it convenient. By the time you get the message, the decision is old. Whatever you say in reply is arriving at a conversation that already finished without you.

Which means the entire skill here is noticing early.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

When a client leaves, the reflex is to go find another one. But churn is a delivery problem, and prospecting harder to cover it is running to stand still.

Why most people get this wrong

The arithmetic is brutal and most people never do it.

Say you're adding two clients a month and losing one. You feel busy — you're doing outreach, you're closing, there's activity everywhere. Net, you're growing by one a month. Now cut the loss to zero and you're growing by two, on identical effort.

The second version isn't twice as good. It's better than that, because the clients who stay refer, and the ones who leave sometimes talk. Retention compounds in both directions.

Two clients in, one out feels like a busy month. It's half a month's growth for a full month's work.

And there's a cost nobody puts in the spreadsheet. A client who leaves unhappy in a market of 200 businesses inside a twenty-minute radius is not a neutral event. That's the same radius your referrals come from.

ADDING MORE IS USUALLY THE WRONG MOVE

Here's the counterintuitive part.

When a client goes quiet, the instinct is to give them more. More reporting. An extra channel. A new deliverable thrown in free. It feels generous and it's usually the wrong response.

Alex Hormozi makes this point in his retention work and it matches what happens in the field: **overwhelm is a leading cause of churn**. Adding things to a relationship that's already unclear makes it less clear. The client didn't want more. He wanted the one thing he bought to visibly work.

The right response to a quiet client is almost always to make the existing result more visible, not to add a new thing to be confused about.

The system

THE LEADING INDICATORS

By the time a client says something, you're late. These are the signals that show up first.

SIGNAL	WHAT IT USUALLY MEANS	RESPONSE WINDOW
Stopped opening the dashboard	Disengaged. Usage churn — still paying, already gone	Days
Slower to reply to you	You've dropped in priority	1-2 weeks
Appointments not being marked as shown or won	Either not following up on leads, or not tracking. Both are bad	Days
Show rate falling with booking rate steady	His follow-through, not your delivery. Fixable, and only if you raise it	Immediately
Asking what something costs	Doing arithmetic about you	Immediately
"Can we hop on a call?" with no topic	Frequently the cancellation call	Before that call
Went quiet after a bad month	Deciding	Immediately

Usage churn is the one to internalize. A client who has stopped logging in has already left; the billing just hasn't caught up. If you intercept at that point you can often save it. If you wait for the invoice, you can't.

THE CHECK-IN THAT PREVENTS THE CANCELLATION

Every two to three weeks, one short message. Not a report — a conversation.

There's a simple structure for this that works because it's how people actually talk. Acknowledge something specific you've seen them do. Say something genuine about it. Then ask one question.

THE CHECK-IN

"Saw you closed the [SPECIFIC JOB] from the appointment that came in Tuesday.

That's the third one from [SOURCE] this month - that channel's working for you.

Quick question: are those the kind of jobs you want more of, or would you rather I push toward [OTHER TYPE]?"

Three things happen. He's reminded you're paying attention. He's reminded the thing is working, in a specific instance rather than a summary. And you get information that makes next month better.

Two minutes. Every two to three weeks. It does more for retention than any feature you could build.

One caution worth knowing: the bigger the client, the less hand-holding they usually want. Read the response rate and adjust — a client who replies in three words doesn't want a longer message, he wants a shorter one.

THE SAVE CONVERSATION

Sometimes it gets to the cancellation anyway. You can save a real portion of these, but only on the phone.

Get them on a call. Text and email cancellations are almost impossible to reverse, because there's no room to hear the actual problem.

Let them say the whole thing. Don't defend anything until they've finished. The complaint you interrupt is not the real one.

Get more annoyed about it than they are. If the problem is legitimate, say so plainly. Only one person gets to be in the angry seat, and if you take it, they can't.

Then find the specific unmet expectation. Usually there's one. "So if the appointments had been showing up at the rate we talked about, you'd have stayed?" Now you know whether it's fixable.

Offer one of two things, not five. Either a redo — a defined window to fix the specific thing, with a date — or a change of fit, which sometimes means a smaller scope and sometimes means letting them go cleanly.

Letting one go cleanly is a real outcome and it's underrated. A client who leaves feeling handled says something different in the hardware store than one who leaves feeling ignored.

TELL THEM ABOUT THE EXIT CONVERSATION UP FRONT

At onboarding, say this: "If you ever want to stop, I just ask for fifteen minutes first — either I fix it or I learn something."

It costs nothing at signing and it converts a cancellation email into a conversation later.

Failure modes

You respond to a quiet client by adding deliverables.

FIX — Make the existing result more visible instead. Adding things to an unclear relationship makes it more confusing, not more valuable.

You only talk to clients when you're reporting.

FIX — Add the two-minute check-in every two to three weeks. It is the cheapest retention work available and almost nobody does it.

You don't notice the dashboard hasn't been opened in three weeks.

FIX — Check engagement weekly. Usage churn precedes actual churn by a month and it's visible the whole time.

You try to save a cancellation over email.

FIX — Get on the phone. If they won't, ask the one question that matters — what specifically would have had to be different.

You blame the client's follow-up without evidence.

FIX — Show the data. "Nineteen booked, six shown — let's look at what happens between the booking and the visit" is a conversation. "You're not following up" is an accusation.

You take the cancellation personally and go quiet.

FIX — Run the exit conversation anyway. The information is worth more than the discomfort, and the way you leave is what gets repeated locally.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Monthly churn. Clients lost this month divided by clients you started the month with. Count only the opening cohort — new clients signed during the month don't change it.

Average client lifetime, in months. Roughly one divided by your monthly churn rate. This is the number that tells you what a client is actually worth, which tells you what you can afford to spend acquiring one.

Reason for every loss. Write it down every time, in the client's words and then in yours. After five, the pattern is usually one thing and it's usually fixable.

What "good" looks like: longer than last quarter. And it's worth knowing that serving very small businesses carries some structural churn — some of them will simply go out of business, and that isn't a reflection on your work. Track it separately from the losses you caused.

DO THIS NOW

25 minutes

If you have clients: open each account and check the last time they logged in or replied. Anyone past two weeks gets the check-in message today.

If you don't have clients yet: write your check-in template and put a recurring task in your calendar for every second Tuesday, starting the week you sign your first one.

Then add one line to your onboarding checklist: "Tell them I ask for fifteen minutes before anyone cancels." Say it on the kickoff call, when it's easy, so it exists later when it isn't.

16

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · STAGE 7 — TIP

Tip the Next Domino

By the end of this chapter you'll turn a delivered result into the next client on purpose, instead of waiting to see whether it happens on its own.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

Client number two. Who they were, and exactly how client number one produced them. Referral, overheard conversation, visible result, someone asking who did it? The precise mechanism — this is the chapter the whole book has been building toward.

AUTHOR NOTE — THIS CHAPTER IS THE THESIS PROVING ITSELF

Everything in this book rests on the claim that each client makes the next one cheaper. That claim is Isaiah's, from his own experience — "one client led to another, the domino effect." The mechanism section below describes how referral flow generally works. It should be replaced or heavily revised with how it actually happened for him, because this is the one place where the reader is entitled to the real story.

This is the chapter the book was built for.

Everything up to here gets you one client and keeps them. This is where one client becomes two, and where the arithmetic of the whole business changes.

Because here's what a referred prospect skips. He skips the cold message. He skips the part where you prove you're a real person. He skips most of "have you done this before." He arrives having already been told by someone he trusts that you're worth the call.

Same offer. Same you. A fraction of the work.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Ask at the moment the result lands, not at renewal. Gratitude has a half-life, and it is much shorter than you think.

Why most people get this wrong

They wait, and they wait for the wrong signal.

The instinct is to wait until you've "earned it" — three months in, a solid track record, the relationship established. By which point the specific thing that made him happy is a general feeling that things are going fine, and general feelings don't produce introductions.

The moment to ask is the moment something specific and good happens. He tells you he closed a \$9,000 job that came off an appointment you booked. That day. Not next quarter.

A referral is not a favor you've earned over time. It's a reflex somebody has in a good moment. Be there for the moment.

The second mistake is asking for a referral rather than for a name.

"Do you know anyone who might need this?" is a question that requires the other person to do a database search of everyone they know while standing in a parking lot. Almost everyone says "let me think about it," which means no.

The system

1. ASK ON THE DAY, NOT ON THE SCHEDULE

Build the trigger into your process. When a client reports a job won — which he does because your monthly report asks him, per Chapter 14 — that's the cue.

Two things happen in the same conversation. You acknowledge the specific result. Then you ask.

2. ASK FOR A CATEGORY, NOT FOR "ANYONE"

The fix for the parking-lot problem is to narrow the search for him.

Instead of "do you know anyone," you name the group. "Who else do you know doing landscaping around Norwood?" or "Who do you use for [an adjacent trade]?"

That's a question with an answer. He can picture two or three faces immediately.

Adjacent trades are the underrated version. A landscaper knows a tree guy, a mason, a fence installer, a pool company. None of them compete with him, all of them have the same problem, and he has no reason to hesitate.

THE REFERRAL ASK

"That's the [Nth] job off this — nice.

Quick thing while I've got you. Who else do you know doing [ADJACENT TRADE] around here? Not asking you to sell anything - just whether there's someone I should introduce myself to."

[He names someone.]

"Perfect. Easiest thing: text him my name and say I did X for you. I'll take it from there. Want me to send you something you can just forward?"

That last line does the real work. Most referrals die because the client agrees and then never does it — not from reluctance, but because writing the message is a small task that never reaches the top of the list.

So you write it for him.

3. SEND THE FORWARDABLE MESSAGE

WHAT YOU SEND HIM TO FORWARD

"Hey [NAME] - the guy who handles our booked estimates is [YOUR NAME]. He set up the system that's been filling our calendar since [MONTH]. Local, over in [TOWN]. Worth a conversation. His number is [NUMBER]."

Short enough to forward without editing. Written in his voice, not yours. And it names the specific thing rather than describing you as a marketing person.

4. CAPTURE THE TESTIMONIAL IN THE SAME MOMENT

The best time to get a testimonial is the same moment as the referral ask, for the same reason.

Ask for something specific rather than general praise. "Would you mind saying what the calendar looked like before, and what it looks like now?" produces something usable. "Would you write a testimonial?" produces three sentences of adjectives.

Get it as a voice note if you can. Voice notes are easier for people to give and far more convincing than text.

GET PERMISSION IN WRITING, AND BE ACCURATE

Before you use a client's name, logo, numbers, or words in your own marketing, get written permission naming exactly what you may use and where. An email reply saying yes is fine — keep it.

Two rules on top of that. Under the FTC's Endorsement Guides, revised effective July 2023, testimonial claims must be truthful and represent typical results, and material connections must be disclosed clearly and conspicuously — so if you paid, discounted, or gave anything in exchange for a testimonial, that has to be disclosed. And if you describe a client's outcome, don't imply it's what a new client should expect unless it genuinely is. In Massachusetts, an overstated claim also runs into c. 93A, which carries treble damages.

Describe what happened. Don't promise it will happen again.

5. WHERE THE REFERRAL ENTERS YOUR PIPELINE

Back at VOLUME, from Chapter 7 — but on a short path.

A referral does not get the cold sequence. It gets a first message that names the person who sent you, and a direct ask for a call. The whole four-part cold anatomy from Chapter 8 collapses, because the proof-you-looked step has already been done by someone he trusts.

Track referred leads separately in your pipeline. Their close rate will be different, and knowing the gap tells you exactly what referral flow is worth — which tells you how much delivery quality is worth, since that's what produces it.

6. WHEN YOU FINALLY NARROW THE LANE

Once you have enough clients, stage seven loops back to stage one.

Look at the ones who stayed longest and paid most. Find what they have in common — vertical, size, how they found you, what they needed. That common thread is the lane you should have picked, and now you know it from data instead of guessing.

Then narrow deliberately. This is the moment where the niche stops being an accident and starts being a choice, and it's a moment you can only reach by having done the work first.

Failure modes

You wait for the right time to ask.

FIX — Ask the day a specific good thing happens. There is no better moment coming, and the one you're in is already fading.

You ask "do you know anyone?"

FIX — Name a category or an adjacent trade. Give him a search he can run in his head in two seconds.

He agrees and nothing happens.

FIX — Send him the forwardable message the same day, written in his voice. The gap between willing and done is a small writing task he'll never get to.

You treat referrals like cold leads.

FIX — Name the referrer in the first line and ask directly for the call. Running a referral through a cold sequence wastes the only advantage it has.

You use a client's name without written permission.

FIX — Ask in writing, keep the reply, and be specific about what you may share. Do it while they're happy.

You never look at what your best clients have in common.

FIX — Run that analysis once you have five or six. It's how the lane stops being luck.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Referrals per client. Introductions received divided by active clients. This is the number that makes the domino real, and it's the one most agencies never measure.

Close rate on referred versus cold. The gap between these two is the value of your delivery quality, expressed as a number. It's also the most persuasive argument you'll ever have for spending time on retention instead of prospecting.

Referral requests made. Track the ask, not just the result. You control asking. If this number is zero, the referral number isn't a mystery.

What "good" looks like: referrals arriving without being asked. That's the signal the domino is running on its own — and it's the point where the arithmetic of the business genuinely changes.

DO THIS NOW

25 minutes

Write two things and save them where you'll find them fast.

One: your referral ask, in your own words, naming a specific adjacent trade in your vertical. Not "anyone" — a category.

Two: the forwardable message, written as if your client wrote it. Third person, short enough to send without editing.

Then add a line to your monthly reporting checklist: "Client reported a job won → ask that day."

If you already have a client who has told you about a closed job in the last month, send the ask now. That moment is still warm and it won't be next week.

17

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · ALL STAGES

Staying Legal

By the end of this chapter you'll know the four rule sets that govern this work, what each one requires of you, and which one is scheduled to change.

READ THIS FIRST

I am not an attorney. Nothing in this chapter is legal advice and reading it creates no attorney-client relationship. This is a working summary written so you know what exists and what to ask about — not a substitute for a licensed attorney in your own state reviewing your actual practices.

Everything here is accurate as of August 2026. Two of these four areas have changed within the last eighteen months and one has a further change scheduled for January 2027. Verify current requirements before you rely on anything in this chapter.

Most people running small agencies have no idea how much regulated activity they're doing.

You're sending text messages to people you don't know. You're recording phone calls. You're making claims about business outcomes in writing. You're publishing testimonials. Every one of those has a rule set attached, and two of them carry criminal or multiplied-damages exposure.

The good news is that compliance here is mostly a handful of specific behaviors, not a legal education. This chapter is that handful.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Four rule sets govern this work: how you message, how you record, what you promise, and how you use proof. Learn what each one requires once, build it into your process, and stop thinking about it.

1. TCPA — how you message

The Telephone Consumer Protection Act governs calls and texts. It's the one with the most active litigation, and the ground has moved twice recently.

WHAT CHANGED, AND WHEN

DATE	WHAT HAPPENED
Jan 2025	The Eleventh Circuit vacated the FCC's "one-to-one consent" rule in Insurance Marketing Coalition v. FCC, holding the FCC had gone beyond its authority in redefining prior express written consent. The rule had been days from taking effect
Apr 2025	The revocation rule took effect — opt-out requests must be honored, and honored promptly
Aug 2025	The FCC reinstated the prior standard for prior express written consent following the vacatur
Jan 2027	Scheduled: the broader "revocation-all" requirement — under which one opt-out would revoke consent across a sender's messaging purposes and channels — takes effect January 31, 2027, having been delayed from 2026

That last row is inside this book's shelf life. If you're reading this in 2027, that change has landed. Check where it stands before you build anything that depends on treating opt-outs channel-by-channel.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

Get real consent and keep the evidence. For marketing messages you need prior express written consent. In practice: a checkbox that isn't pre-ticked, consent

language visible next to the submit button, and a stored record of what the form said, when they submitted, and from what IP.

Honor opt-outs immediately and broadly. Don't be clever about the scope. Someone who says stop, stops — across everything you're sending them. Given what's scheduled for 2027, building this the broad way now means you don't rebuild later.

Registration is not consent. Chapter 11 gets your messages delivered by the carriers. It has nothing to do with whether you had permission to send them. Two different systems, two different exposures.

Interrogate every list a client hands you. This is the one that catches agencies. A client gives you 4,000 contacts and says "these are all customers." Ask how they were collected, when, and what they agreed to. Put responsibility for consent in the agreement, per Chapter 6 — and still ask, because a contract clause doesn't undo a message you already sent.

2. Massachusetts recording law — how you record

If you record sales calls, and Chapter 9 suggests you might, this applies to you.

IT'S A SECRECY STATUTE, NOT A CONSENT STATUTE

Massachusetts is commonly called a "two-party consent" state. That shorthand is close enough for conversation and slightly wrong in a way that matters.

M.G.L. c. 272 § 99 defines "interception" as to **secretly** hear or record a wire or oral communication. Secretly is the operative word in every offense under the statute.

The practical effect is straightforward and easier than the shorthand suggests: **if everyone knows the recording is happening, there is no violation.** An announcement at the top of the call — including an automated one — puts the parties on notice.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

Announce it before the conversation starts. The opening frame in Chapter 9 has the line built in. Get an acknowledgment.

Understand the interstate rule. Massachusetts law governs recordings made in-state regardless of where the other party is located. The federal one-party-consent baseline does not override it.

Take it seriously. This is a felony statute — up to five years in state prison and a \$10,000 fine, plus civil damages. Almost nothing else in this book carries criminal exposure. This does, and avoiding it costs you one sentence at the start of a call.

If you don't want to deal with it, don't record. That's a legitimate choice. What isn't legitimate is recording quietly.

3. Chapter 93A — what you promise

Covered in Chapter 6, restated here because it touches everything.

M.G.L. c. 93A prohibits unfair or deceptive acts in trade or commerce. **Section 9** covers consumers; **section 11** covers business-to-business claims. Your client is a business, so section 11 is your exposure.

The remedy is what makes it sharp. Where a violation was willful or knowing, or where a party refused to settle in bad faith after a written demand, a court can award **up to treble damages plus the other side's attorney's fees**. In a dispute over a modest monthly engagement, the fees can exceed the amount in dispute several times over.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

Describe the service, never predict their income. "Six booked estimates a month" is a commitment you define and control. "This will add \$40,000 to your year" is a prediction about someone else's business.

Audit every document you send. Proposal, pitch deck, email templates, the note in your phone, your website. Search for guarantee, will make, ROI, and promise.

Deliver what the agreement says. The cleanest 93A defense is a clear scope you met.

4. FTC Endorsement Guides — how you use proof

Revised effective **July 26, 2023** (16 CFR Part 255). This governs testimonials and endorsements — both yours and the ones you create for clients.

WHAT IT REQUIRES

Material connections must be disclosed. Paid, discounted, gifted, employed, related — if there's a connection between you and the endorser that a consumer wouldn't expect, disclose it.

Claims must be truthful and represent typical results. A best-case outcome presented as representative is deceptive.

"Clear and conspicuous" has teeth. The standard is that a disclosure be difficult to miss and easily understood by ordinary consumers — unavoidable, standing out by color, size, placement, and duration. Fine print at the bottom does not meet it.

The definition of endorsement is broad. It covers reviews, tags, social mentions, virtual influencers, fake reviews, and organizational seals — not just formal testimonials.

WHAT TO ACTUALLY DO

Get written permission before using any client's name, numbers, or words. Keep the reply.

Label results honestly. If a result is exceptional, say so.

Check the ad copy you write for clients. This is the part agencies miss. If you write a claim on a client's behalf that overstates what their customers typically get, you built their exposure. Review your own creative against this rule, because they're not going to.

The asset

MESSAGING (TCPA)

- ☐ Consent checkbox not pre-ticked
- ☐ Consent language visible at the point of submission
- ☐ Record stored: what it said, when, from where
- ☐ Opt-outs honored immediately and across all sending
- ☐ Every client-supplied list interrogated before use
- ☐ Consent responsibility written into the agreement
- ☐ Diary check: revocation-all rule, Jan 31 2027

RECORDING (M.G.L. c. 272 s.99 - MA)

- ☐ Announcement at the top of every recorded call
- ☐ Acknowledgment captured
- ☐ Applies to any call recorded in Massachusetts

PROMISES (M.G.L. c. 93A s.11 - MA)

- ☐ No income claims anywhere in writing
- ☐ Scope stated positively and negatively
- ☐ Searched all documents for: guarantee / will make / ROI / promise

PROOF (FTC Endorsement Guides, rev. July 2023)

- ☐ Written permission on file per client
- ☐ Material connections disclosed
- ☐ Results labeled typical or exceptional, honestly
- ☐ Client ad copy reviewed against the same standard

ANNUAL

- ☐ Attorney review of MSA / SOW templates
- ☐ Re-check every date and rule in this chapter

Full version: **Compliance Quick-Reference** in the asset vault.

Failure modes

You treat carrier registration as permission to message.

FIX — They're separate systems. Registration gets delivery; consent gets you the right to send. You need both.

You message a client's list without asking where it came from.

FIX — Ask how, when, and what they agreed to — before the first send. A contract clause allocates the risk; it doesn't unsend the message.

You honor an opt-out only on the channel it arrived on.

FIX — Apply it across everything now. It's the right thing and it's where the rules are heading in January 2027.

You record calls without announcing it.

FIX — Add the line to your opening frame today. Felony exposure, four-second fix.

An income claim survives in an old proposal template.

FIX — Search every document you send, including the ones you forgot you had. One old file is enough.

You publish a client result without permission.

FIX — Email, ask specifically, keep the reply. Ask while the relationship is good.

You assume this chapter stays accurate.

FIX — Diary an annual re-check. Two of these four areas moved in the last eighteen months.

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Percentage of active sending with documented consent on file. Target is 100%. Anything less is a number you should be able to state exactly.

Documents containing a results promise. Target is zero. Search quarterly.

Date of last compliance review. If it's more than twelve months old, it's out of date — two of these four areas changed inside the last eighteen months.

What "good" looks like: you can produce the consent record for any contact you've messaged, within five minutes, without asking anyone.

DO THIS NOW

40 minutes

Three passes, in order.

One. Open every document you send a prospect or client. Search for guarantee, will make, ROI, and promise. Rewrite every hit as a description of the service.

Two. Open your intake form. Check the consent checkbox isn't pre-ticked and the language sits next to the submit button. Fix it if not.

Three. Put two recurring reminders in your calendar. One for January 2027 to check where the TCPA revocation-all rule landed. One annual, to re-read this chapter against current law.

That third one is the whole point. This chapter will go out of date. The reminder is what keeps you from going out of date with it.

18

THE DOMINO SYSTEM · THE HONEST ACCOUNTING

What I'd Do Differently

By the end of this chapter you'll know what the mistakes cost, so you can skip the expensive ones.

STORY NEEDED — COLD OPEN, 150-300 WORDS

The biggest failure. The client lost, the refund issued, the campaign that produced nothing. What broke, what it cost, and what changed afterward. This chapter fails without it — a "what I'd do differently" chapter with no real mistake in it is worthless, and every reader will know.

AUTHOR NOTE — THIS CHAPTER IS ENTIRELY ISAIAH'S

The frame below is structural. The content has to be his actual mistakes, with real specifics. A skeptical reader who has been burned by a guru course reads this chapter first, and generic regret will lose them permanently. Anything that can't be told honestly should be cut rather than softened.

Every course you've ever seen ends with a chapter like this, and most of them are dishonest.

They pick safe mistakes. "I should have started sooner." "I should have believed in myself more." Those aren't mistakes, they're compliments in a costume.

A real mistake has a number attached and it still stings a little.

The principle

THE PRINCIPLE

Most of what you'll get wrong is not strategy. It's sequencing, pricing, and saying yes to people you should have turned down.

The ones that cost the most

EACH HEADING BELOW NEEDS THE REAL VERSION

These are the categories where new agency operators most reliably lose money, offered as prompts. Each should be replaced with what actually happened, with specifics — or removed if it didn't happen.

UNDERPRICING THE FIRST ONES

The most common expensive mistake in this business, and the hardest to reverse.

You charge a low number to get the first yes. It works. Then the client refers someone, and the referral expects the same price. Then that one refers someone. Eighteen months later your entire book is priced off a number you picked when you were nervous.

Raising prices on new clients is easy. Raising them on a referral network built off your original number is a year of awkward conversations.

[STORY NEEDED: what you charged first, how long you stayed there, and what it cost you.]

BUILDING BEFORE REGISTERING

Chapter 11 exists because of this. The sequencing error that spends a new client's patience on a form.

[STORY NEEDED: the client who waited, and what that wait did to the relationship.]

SAYING YES TO A CLIENT WHOSE ARITHMETIC DIDN'T WORK

Sooner or later someone wants to hire you and the numbers don't support it. The job value is too low, or the market is too thin, or they can't handle the volume they're asking for.

You take them anyway, because revenue is revenue and you're starting out.

Then you spend four months failing to deliver something that was never available, absorb the churn, and possibly the reputational cost in a small market. The revenue was never worth it.

[STORY NEEDED: the client you should have turned down.]

LETTING SCOPE GROW ONE FAVOR AT A TIME

Nobody agrees to a bad scope. It arrives in pieces, each of them small and reasonable, over months.

[STORY NEEDED: the engagement that turned into something else, and where it started.]

STOPPING OUTREACH AFTER LANDING A CLIENT

Delivery expands to fill the week. Outreach stops. Sixty days later the pipeline is empty and you're doing cold outreach from zero while also delivering — which is the worst possible time to do it.

[STORY NEEDED: the gap month, if there was one.]

What I'd tell myself at the start

THIS SECTION IS THE EMOTIONAL CLOSE OF THE BOOK

Five or six short pieces of advice from Isaiah to himself at nineteen or twenty. Not general life advice — specific to this business and this work. Written the way he'd say it to a friend, not the way a book ends.

[STORY NEEDED: the five things.]

The metric

WHAT TO TRACK IN THIS STAGE

Your own mistake list. Keep it. One line each: what happened, what it cost, what changed.

Most people carry their mistakes as a vague feeling of having messed up, which teaches nothing. Written down with a number attached, the same mistake becomes a rule you follow without thinking.

Review it every quarter. If a mistake appears twice, that isn't a mistake any more — it's a habit, and it needs a process change rather than more resolve.

What "good" looks like: a list that gets longer and less expensive over time.

DO THIS NOW

20 minutes

Start the list. One document, three columns: what happened, what it cost, what I changed.

If you're at the beginning and have no entries yet, write the headers and put the first thing you get wrong in it this month. You will get something wrong this month.

Then put a recurring reminder in your calendar for the first of every quarter to read it. That reading is the entire value of the exercise, and without the reminder it won't happen.

The Asset Vault

Every script, template, worksheet, and checklist in this book exists as a standalone file you can fill in. Use those instead of retyping out of the book.

ASSET	CHAPTER	WHAT IT'S FOR
Daily Rep Tracker	2	The three numbers, one row per day
Niche Selection Scorecard	3	Weighted scoring for three verticals
Offer Builder Worksheet	4	Seven fields to one sellable sentence
Three-Tier Pricing Calculator	5	Setup and retainer per tier, with the logic
MSA Skeleton	6	Master agreement, annotated clause by clause
SOW Skeleton	6	Statement of work, one per engagement
Proposal Template	6	What you send after the discovery call
Outreach Pipeline Spec	7	Six stages, plus the repeatable outreach day
Cold Outreach Scripts	8	DM, email, cold call, walk-in
Discovery Call Framework	9	The six moves, with the opening frame
Discovery Question Bank	9	Every question, grouped and ordered
Objection Handling One-Pager	10	Twelve objections, what each means
A2P 10DLC Registration Checklist	11	Day-one submission, start to approval
GoHighLevel Build Checklist	12	Dependency-ordered build, with test steps
Client Onboarding Checklist	13	Day 0 to day 14
SMS & Email Nurture Sequences	13	Speed-to-lead and reminders, with compliance notes
Weekly Reporting Template	14	The four numbers and three sentences
KPI Dashboard Definitions	14	What to track, the formula, and why
Retention / QBR Script	15	Check-in and save conversation
Referral & Testimonial Capture Kit	16	The ask, and the forwardable message
Compliance Quick-Reference	17	All four rule sets, as a checklist
30/60/90 Execution Plan	Back matter	The whole book as a calendar

Every template touching contracts, consent, or claims carries this header, and it isn't decoration:

TEMPLATE ONLY - NOT LEGAL ADVICE.

Review with a licensed attorney in your state before use.

WHAT I'D DO DIFFERENTLY

The 30/60/90 Execution Plan

The whole book as a calendar. If you do nothing else, do this in this order.

DAYS 1–30 · GET TO YOUR FIRST CONVERSATION

The goal of month one is not a client. It's a working outreach habit and a real pipeline.

- ☐ Write your attempt-number commitment and the date (Ch. 1)
- ☐ Find your daily block and set the recurring calendar event (Ch. 2)
- ☐ Score three verticals, pick one, draw the radius (Ch. 3)
- ☐ Count the qualifying businesses inside it (Ch. 3)
- ☐ Fill the offer builder and say the one-sentence version out loud ten times (Ch. 4)
- ☐ Do the job-value arithmetic for one real business (Ch. 5)
- ☐ Set your setup fee and monthly (Ch. 5)
- ☐ Book the attorney review of your MSA and SOW (Ch. 6)
- ☐ Build the six-stage outreach pipeline (Ch. 7)
- ☐ Add 200+ businesses to Cold (Ch. 7)
- ☐ Write your four-part message for two channels (Ch. 8)
- ☐ Start your own A2P 10DLC brand registration (Ch. 11)
- ☐ **Hit your daily number every single day**

DAYS 31–60 · GET TO YOUR FIRST CLIENT

Month two is conversations. Your outreach is running; now the skill is on the call.

- ☐ Write and rehearse your opening frame (Ch. 9)
- ☐ Build your fifteen-question discovery sheet (Ch. 9)
- ☐ Write your answer to all twelve objections and say each out loud (Ch. 10)
- ☐ Run calls. Tally which objections actually appear (Ch. 10)
- ☐ Review stage-to-stage conversion weekly; fix the biggest drop-off (Ch. 7)
- ☐ Build the client-side pipeline and the speed-to-lead automation (Ch. 12)
- ☐ Test the whole path as a fake lead from your own phone (Ch. 12)
- ☐ Write your day 0–14 onboarding checklist (Ch. 13)
- ☐ Audit every document for income claims (Ch. 6, 17)
- ☐ **Keep hitting your daily number, including on call days**

DAYS 61–90 · DELIVER, PROVE, AND TIP THE NEXT ONE

Month three is where the domino either starts or doesn't. It starts with delivery.

- ☐ Submit client A2P registration within one business day of signature (Ch. 11)
- ☐ Send a progress note every 2–3 days during the registration wait (Ch. 13)
- ☐ Get real calendar availability in writing (Ch. 13)
- ☐ Build the reminder stack (Ch. 13)
- ☐ Call the client the day the first appointment books (Ch. 13)
- ☐ Build the one-page report and send it on time (Ch. 14)
- ☐ Set the two-week check-in as a recurring task (Ch. 15)
- ☐ Ask for a referral the day a job is reported won (Ch. 16)
- ☐ Get written permission before using any result publicly (Ch. 16, 17)
- ☐ Snapshot the build so the next one takes hours (Ch. 12)
- ☐ Start your mistake list (Ch. 18)
- ☐ **Still hitting the daily number**

If you notice one instruction repeating in all three months, that's not an editing error. It's the book.

Glossary

A2P 10DLC — Application-to-Person messaging over a 10-digit long code. What your CRM does when it sends a text. Requires carrier registration; unregistered traffic is blocked.

Activation point — The specific thing a customer does or receives that separates the ones who stay from the ones who leave. For a lead-gen agency, most likely the client's first booked appointment.

BAMFAM — Book a meeting from a meeting. Never end a call without the next one scheduled.

Brand (A2P) — The registered business identity behind messaging. Legal name, EIN, address. One per business.

CAC — Customer acquisition cost. What it costs you, in money or hours, to land one client.

Campaign (A2P) — A registered messaging use case under a brand, with sample messages and an opt-in description. A brand can have several.

Churn — Customers lost in a period, divided by the customers you started that period with. New signups during the period don't change it.

Cold — A prospect on your list who has never been contacted. The first stage of the outreach pipeline.

Consent (TCPA) — The recipient's permission to be messaged. Separate from carrier registration, which only governs delivery.

Lookback window — The period a client actually judges you over, which is the last billing cycle rather than the whole relationship.

LTV — Lifetime value. What a client is worth across the relationship. Roughly monthly revenue divided by monthly churn.

MSA — Master Services Agreement. The rules of the relationship, signed once.

Show rate — Booked appointments that turned up, as a percentage of appointments booked.

Snapshot — A saved template of a fully built client account, used so the next build starts from something rather than nothing.

SOW — Statement of Work. What you're doing, for how much, over what period. One per engagement.

Speed to lead — Elapsed time between an inquiry arriving and your first contact attempt. Measured in seconds.

Structural churn — Clients lost because their business closed, rather than because of anything you did. Track it separately.

Throughput — The percentage of engaged leads who end up showing to an appointment. Schedule rate multiplied by show rate.

Usage churn — A client who has stopped using the product but is still paying. A leading indicator of actual churn.

Sources and attribution

FRAMEWORKS CREDITED TO OTHERS

Several ideas in this book originate with other people. They're named in the text where they appear, and this is the consolidated list. What's here is attribution and commentary — the applications, examples, and instructions throughout the book are my own.

Alex Hormozi — the ideal-customer screens in Chapter 3; the three pricing models and the value-based approach in Chapter 5; the value equation referenced in Chapter 4; the lookback window in Chapters 5 and 14; the activation point method in Chapter 13; the four drivers of appointment show rate in Chapter 13; and the observation in Chapter 15 that overwhelm drives churn.

Sharran Srivatsaa — booking a meeting from a meeting, Chapter 9, which I came to through Hormozi's lead nurture work.

Warren Buffett — the observation that price is what you pay and value is what you get, referenced in Chapter 5.

RESEARCH CITED

Two studies are cited in this book. Both are named with their authors and dates so you can read them yourself, which you should — and both are old enough that you should weigh them accordingly.

Lead response time. James B. Oldroyd, Kristina McElheran and David Elkington, "The Short Life of Online Sales Leads," Harvard Business Review 89, no. 3 (March 2011). An audit of 2,241 US companies. Firms attempting contact within an hour of an inquiry were roughly seven times more likely to qualify the lead than those trying an hour later, and more than sixty times more likely than those waiting a day. Cited in Chapter 12.

Retention economics. Frederick F. Reichheld and W. Earl Sasser Jr., "Zero Defections: Quality Comes to Services," Harvard Business Review, September-October 1990. Found that reducing customer defections by 5% raised profits by 25% to 85%, with the largest gains in a bank branch system.

That second one is worth a note. You'll see this figure quoted almost everywhere as **25% to 95%**. It isn't. The original says 25% to 85%, and the higher number is a misquote that spread through marketing writing until it became the version people repeat. I've used the correct figure, and I'd encourage you to check any statistic you're about to repeat in your own marketing — including the ones in this book.

ON STATISTICS GENERALLY

Several figures commonly cited in agency training — response-time averages, follow-up attempt counts, acquisition-versus-retention cost ratios — could not be traced to a locatable primary source when I went looking. I've left them out rather than repeat them.

If a number matters enough to put in front of a client, it matters enough to find the study.

COMPLIANCE SOURCES

Chapter 17 reflects: FCC and Eleventh Circuit developments on the TCPA between January 2025 and January 2026, including Insurance Marketing Coalition v. FCC; Massachusetts General Laws chapter 272 § 99; Massachusetts General Laws chapter 93A, sections 9 and 11; and the FTC's revised Guides Concerning the Use of Endorsements and Testimonials in Advertising, 16 CFR Part 255, effective July 26, 2023.

All of it was accurate as of August 2026 and none of it is legal advice.

Before publication — internal clearance list

REMOVE THIS PAGE FROM THE RETAIL BUILD

This page exists for Isaiah, not the reader. The retail build strips story slots automatically with `build.sh --retail`; this whole section should be deleted from `build/back/` before the version that goes on sale.

CLIENT NAMES REQUIRING WRITTEN PERMISSION

Every real client name must be cleared in writing before it appears in the book or in any marketing for it. Named in the author dossier and not yet cleared:

- ☐ [CLIENT NAME — CONFIRM PERMISSION] Quick N' Clean — auto detailing
- ☐ [CLIENT NAME — CONFIRM PERMISSION] Akira Real Estate, Dedham MA
- ☐ [CLIENT NAME — CONFIRM PERMISSION] Any landscaping client referenced in a story slot
- ☐ [CLIENT NAME — CONFIRM PERMISSION] Any client whose numbers appear in a case study

For each: get written permission naming exactly what may be used — name, logo, numbers, quote — and where. Keep the reply. If permission isn't given, anonymize by trade and town rather than cutting the story.

STORY SLOTS STILL OPEN

Run `grep -rn "STORY NEEDED" build/chapters/` for the live list. Chapters 1, 8, 10, 16 and 18 cannot ship without their material — the rest are enriched by it but stand without.

VERIFICATION BEFORE PUBLICATION

- ☐ Every number in the book is either measured by Isaiah or labeled illustrative
- ☐ No income claims anywhere, including in story slots once filled
- ☐ Attorney review of MSA, SOW, and Proposal templates completed
- ☐ Chapter 11 fees and timelines re-checked against current carrier requirements
- ☐ Chapter 17 re-checked against current law, and the date line updated
- ☐ Real logo file substituted for the reconstructed vector mark
- ☐ Wordmark set in the real typeface, outlined